

COCKATOO · FAMILY CACATUIDAE

The most demanding parrot people bring home.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual for a bird that may outlive you: the honest decision test, training and foraging as the plan against plucking, screaming, feather dust and your own lungs, and a succession plan for the sixty-year animal in the corner of your living room.

INSIDE

- ✓ A decision page written to talk some readers out of the bird
- ✓ Five species compared on size, price, noise and temperament
- ✓ Training, foraging and independence, and what the evidence supports
- ✓ Seven health pages, a symptom table, and fillable owner and vet sheets

46 pages

Advanced

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you have not bought a bird yet

Read page 5 first, before anything else in this book, and answer it honestly. It is the only page here written with the intention of talking some readers out of the purchase, and it exists because cockatoos are among the most frequently surrendered parrots there are. If you get through it and still want one, page 6 decides *which* cockatoo, which changes the price, the noise, the cage and the lifespan more than most buyers expect. Then read section 02 and section 03 before you buy anything, and use page 34 so you buy once.

If your cockatoo is already home

Start with page 16, because short daily training sessions are the most useful habit in this book: structured attention is what a cockatoo needs most, and no toy supplies it. Then page 15 and page 9. If the bird screams, plucks or has become a one-person animal that lunges at everyone else, pages 18 through 19 are the ones to work through, and they work better before the behavior is entrenched than after. If anything looks physically wrong, go to Health Red Flags on page 23.

Print these first

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|--|--|
| ☐ Page 32: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 39: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 33: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 40: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 41: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 31: Succession & Rehoming Plan |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Cockatoos are sold on the cuddling. A hand-raised baby cockatoo is one of the most affectionate animals anybody will ever meet, and almost nothing in a shop tells the buyer what that same bird needs at eight years old, or what happens when it does not get it. This book is written to close that gap: what the day actually looks like, what the noise actually is, what the dust does to a house, and what happens to the bird when you are seventy. Every figure is cross-checked against veterinary sources, listed on pages 44 and 45, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian, and for an entrenched behavior problem, a certified avian behavior consultant. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. This species has the highest concentration of serious behavioral problems of any commonly kept parrot, and the professionals who work with them exist for a reason. Find both before you need them and write the numbers on page 33.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Written around the umbrella cockatoo, with the range across commonly kept species. Page 6 splits them out.

Family	Cacatuidae, the cockatoos. Twenty-one species, of which perhaps six are commonly kept. The cockatiel is the smallest member of this same family
Reference species here	The umbrella cockatoo, <i>Cacatua alba</i> , from the Maluku Islands of Indonesia
Adult size	12 to 28 in (30 to 70 cm) across the family. An umbrella is about 18 in (46 cm)
Adult weight	Goffin's about 350 g, umbrella 400 to 700 g, Moluccan and greater sulphur-crested up to about 880 g. Page 6
Captive lifespan	25 to 45 years is typical , and the larger species reach 70 to 80 or more. Plan for a bird that outlives you. Page 31
Sexual maturity	3 to 4 years in medium species, 5 to 6 in large ones. This is when a sweet bird often becomes a difficult one. Page 17
Weaning	90 to 120 days in medium species, 120 to 150 in large ones. A bird sold unweaned is a red flag
Cage minimum	36×24×48 in (91×61×122 cm), with 48×48×60 in (122×122×152 cm) as the real target. Page 7
Bar spacing	3/4 to 1 in (19 to 25 mm) for a large cockatoo, on heavy-gauge stainless or powder-coated steel. Never galvanized
Perch diameter	3/4 to 2 in (19 to 51 mm), varied
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Darkness needed	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, every night. Page 9
Body temperature	About 106.2°F (41.2°C). Heart rate about 147 bpm (beats per minute) in a 500 g bird, breathing 15 to 40 a minute
Daily interaction	4 to 6 hours on most days. This is the number the whole decision turns on. Page 5
Noise	Among the loudest birds anybody keeps. Screams carry through walls, and quieting one is not an achievable goal. Page 19
Handling difficulty	Advanced. Not a first parrot, and not a second one either
Conservation status	The umbrella is Endangered on the Red List of the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature), the global list of threatened species. Several species are on Appendix I of CITES (the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species, the treaty that controls the international wildlife trade): its strictest list, for species threatened with extinction. Page 30

Cost overview

Getting started

The bird is **\$700 to \$3,000** for a common species, with umbrellas at \$1,000 to \$3,000 and Moluccans \$1,400 to \$3,500. A rescue fee is \$300 to \$800 and adoptable birds are not rare. Add cage, stand, toys, air purifier and a first vet visit and a realistic total is **\$2,200 to \$7,300**. Page 34.

Every year

Food is the small line. **Destructible toys are the big one**, because a cockatoo destroying them is the system working. Budget **\$878 to \$1,995 a year** including an annual exam. Across a 40-year life that is \$35,000 to \$80,000, before a single emergency.

THE REPUTATION IS EARNED, AND IT IS ON THE RECORD

A parrot behavior consultant who specializes in this problem reports that clients with cockatoos make up **more than half of her entire consulting practice**. Rescues routinely describe cockatoos as the bird they take in most. That is not a rumor about a difficult species, it is a measured pattern, and page 5 explains what causes it.

Is a cockatoo right for you?

The only page in this series written to change some readers' minds. Answer it before you buy, not after.

Cockatoos are extremely social, extremely intelligent, extremely loud, extremely destructive and extremely long-lived, and the combination produces more behavioral problems than any other commonly kept parrot. The bird is not defective. Screaming and plucking are, in large part, a direct readout of unmet needs. But it means the difference between a wonderful cockatoo and a tragic one is almost entirely what the household can provide, every day, for decades.

Nine questions. Answer them out loud.

QUESTION	WHY IT DECIDES
Can I give this bird 4 to 6 hours of real engagement most days?	Not company in the same room. Interaction. This is the figure behind the surrenders
Will that still be true in ten years, through a job change, a baby, or an illness?	The commonest surrender story is a life that changed, not an owner who stopped caring
Can my household tolerate screaming that carries through walls?	Dawn and dusk contact calling is normal behavior, not a fault to be trained out. Page 19
Do I own the building, or will a neighbor complain?	Noise is the second commonest reason a cockatoo is rehomed. Renting with one is genuinely hard
Is anyone here asthmatic or immunocompromised?	Cockatoos produce very heavy feather dust. Page 10 is not optional reading
Can I afford \$900 to \$2,000 a year, plus emergencies, indefinitely?	Chronic conditions in this species are expensive and common. Page 34
Am I willing to have my woodwork, furniture and baseboards destroyed?	Destruction is normal behavior. A bird with nothing sanctioned to destroy picks your house, or itself
Do I have a plan for the bird if it outlives me?	A 40-year animal needs a named person and money set aside. Page 31
Have I met an adult cockatoo, not a baby?	Babies are uniformly sweet. The animal you are buying is the one at eight years old

IF MORE THAN TWO ANSWERS ARE "PROBABLY"

Then the honest recommendation is a different bird. That is not a judgment about you. A cockatoo whose needs go unmet does not become a slightly worse pet, it becomes a screaming, self-mutilating animal in a spare room, and then it becomes a rescue's problem. The cockatiel, which is a small cockatoo and shares much of the charm, is a genuinely realistic alternative for a normal household. So is a rescue cockatoo you visit weekly rather than one you own.

Two things that make it work, and one that does not

- **A household, not a person.** A bird that accepts several people has several sources of company and does not collapse when one of them goes to work. Building this deliberately from day one is page 18, and it is the highest-leverage thing a new owner does
- **Structured time, not just presence.** Two short training sessions a day beat an afternoon on your shoulder while you work. Page 16
- **Not more toys.** They matter, and they are on page 15, but what a toy cannot supply is attention. No product substitutes for it

CONSIDER ADOPTION SERIOUSLY

Rescue fees run \$300 to \$800 against \$1,000 to \$3,500 for a baby, and adoptable cockatoos are not rare precisely because of everything on this page. An adult bird also shows you who it actually is, which a hand-raised baby cannot. A good rescue is honest about a bird's history, takes it back if it does not work, and is far more useful to you at year three than a shop will be.

SECTION 01

Which cockatoo

"Cockatoo" covers birds that differ by a factor of three in weight and ten in price. This decision comes before the cage does.

SPECIES	WEIGHT	TYPICAL PRICE	WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY GETTING
Goffin's <i>Cacatua goffiniana</i>	About 350 g	\$700 to \$2,000	The smallest commonly kept, and remarkable problem solvers. Less overwhelming in size and volume than a white macaw-sized bird, no less demanding in occupation. Chews relentlessly and escapes cages routinely
Galah Rose-breasted, <i>Eolophus roseicapilla</i>	300 to 400 g	\$700 to \$2,500	Often described as the most robust temperament in the family, and less prone to the extreme bonding. Genuinely prone to obesity, and named alongside macaws and Amazons in the veterinary literature for it. Page 26
Umbrella <i>Cacatua alba</i>	400 to 700 g	\$1,000 to \$3,000	The archetype of everything on page 5. Extraordinarily affectionate, extraordinarily loud, and the species most associated with separation-related behavior. IUCN Endangered
Sulphur-crested <i>Cacatua galerita</i>	Up to about 880 g	\$1,000 to \$3,000	Large, powerful, long-lived and extremely loud. The species the feather-plucking treatment study on page 16 was run in
Moluccan Salmon-crested, <i>Cacatua moluccensis</i>	About 850 g	\$1,400 to \$3,500	The largest and loudest of the commonly kept white cockatoos, and among the longest-lived, at 70 to 80 years or more. CITES Appendix I, which has real legal consequences in some states. Page 30
Palm <i>Probosciger aterrimus</i>	Very large	\$2,000 to \$16,000	Specialist keeping, specialist price, and outside the scope of a general care package. Named here only so you know what you are looking at

WHAT DOES NOT CHANGE BETWEEN THEM

Every commonly kept cockatoo is highly social, highly intelligent, loud, destructive and long-lived. There is **no low-maintenance cockatoo**. A smaller species buys you a smaller cage, a smaller food bill and a quieter bird by degrees, not a different animal. Do not read this page as a way around the commitment on page 5.

Where the bird comes from

SOURCE	WHAT TO KNOW
Rescue or sanctuary	\$300 to \$800. The bird's temperament is already visible, its history is usually known, and a good organization stays involved. The strongest option for most buyers, and the one this book recommends
A small breeder	Ask to see the parents, the weaning arrangements and the testing. A bird should be fully weaned before it leaves: 90 to 150 days depending on species. Hand-feeding an unweaned cockatoo is specialist work and a bird sold unweaned is a bird sold too early
A shop	The weakest option. Birds from multiple sources sharing air is what page 29 exists to prevent, and staff rarely know a bird's history

Hand-raised is not a free upgrade. The socialization to people is the appeal and is real. Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006) found hand-reared parrots also imprint on people and become socially dependent, with more aggression, feather picking and stereotyped behavior than parent-reared birds. In the species whose defining failure mode is over-bonding (page 18), that is worth knowing.

FOUR QUESTIONS FOR THE SELLER

Has it been tested for PBFD (psittacine beak and feather disease, a viral disease that destroys feathers and the beak), polyomavirus and chlamydia, and can I see the results? Is it fully weaned, and on what? Has it ever plucked, screamed persistently, or been returned? And will you take the bird back if my vet finds a problem in the first week? A seller worth buying from answers all four without hesitating.

Cage size, bar gauge, locks & placement

The most expensive object you will buy, and the one most often bought twice.

The commonly cited minimum for a large cockatoo is **36 in wide by 24 in deep by 48 in tall (91×61×122 cm)**, with many avian vets recommending closer to **48×48×60 in (122×122×152 cm)** as genuinely comfortable. Bigger is always better here, and a cage top that opens into a play stand is the best arrangement there is, because it turns the cage into a base rather than a container.

A cage is a baseline, not the answer. No cage you can fit in a house is large enough for a bird this size to exercise properly, which is why the out-of-cage hours on page 8 are the part that actually matters.

BAR GAUGE, SPACING AND LOCKS

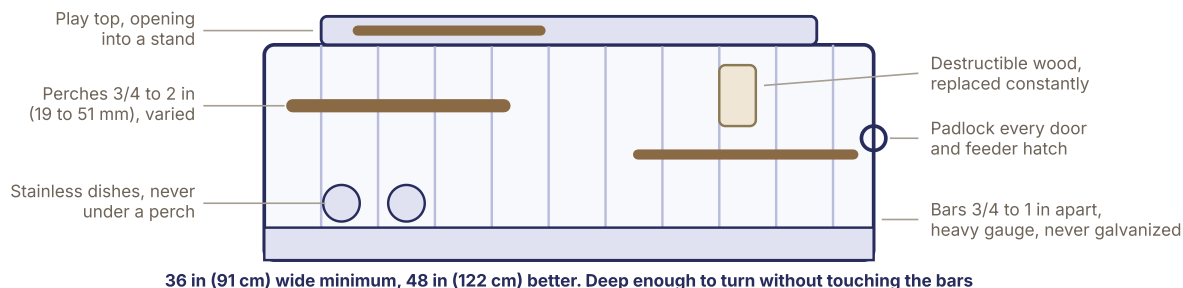
Bar spacing 3/4 to 1 in (19 to 25 mm) for a large cockatoo, on genuinely heavy-gauge bar. A cockatoo's beak bends thin cage wire, and a bird that opens the cage while you are at work is loose in a house of hazards for eight hours.

Assume the latch will be defeated. Cockatoos are notorious escape artists with both the intelligence and the strength to work out standard fastenings, and cage-specific padlocks or spring clips on every door and feeder hatch are standard practice rather than paranoia.

Never galvanized or zinc-coated. A cockatoo chews the bars, and that coating is a zinc source. Stainless steel is the gold standard, rust-proof, non-toxic and able to survive this beak for decades. Heavy-gauge powder-coated steel is the affordable alternative and is acceptable. Page 27 on what metal poisoning does.

Where it goes

PLACE	WHY
A social room the family uses	Isolation is more damaging to this species than to any other parrot on this site. A cockatoo in a spare room is the first step in the plucking story on page 24
Against a wall, not floating in space	One solid side to back into. Corner placement suits most birds better than the middle of a room
Not the kitchen, on any account	Overheated nonstick cookware kills birds. Page 11 has the temperature and the mechanism
Somewhere you can clean hard, daily	This species produces more powder down than almost anything else kept. Carpet under a cockatoo cage is a mistake you make once. Page 10
Somewhere that can be made dark and quiet	10 to 12 hours of real darkness is a health requirement in this species specifically, because sleep deprivation measurably worsens screaming. Page 9
Out of all-day sun and off drafts	A caged bird cannot move out of the sun



Perches, play stands & out-of-cage space

The hours outside the cage are the ones that decide how this bird turns out.

Perches

Varied diameters from **3/4 to 2 in (19 to 51 mm)**, in several materials, at several heights. A cage of identical dowels loads the same points of a large bird's foot continuously, and a heavy bird develops pressure sores faster than a small one does. Natural hardwood branch is the best surface there is and it is free: apple, willow, eucalyptus and manzanita, unsprayed, scrubbed and dried.

Expect to replace them. A cockatoo reduces a perch to splinters, and that is the perch working as intended rather than a waste of money. Budget perches as a consumable on page 34.

Out-of-cage space, which is the real requirement

A cockatoo needs **hours out of the cage daily**, in a proofed room, with things to climb and chew and somewhere to be that is not your shoulder. Three arrangements, and most households end up with all three:

SETUP	WHAT IT DOES
A cage-top play area	The cheapest useful hour of the day. The bird is out, in the room, occupied, and it goes back down without a chase
A free-standing play stand	Puts the bird somewhere in the room that is not the cage and not you. Essential for the independence work on page 18
A proofed room	Where actual exercise happens. Windows covered, fans off, cables and baseboards protected, other pets out. Page 11

DESTRUCTION IS THE POINT, NOT THE PROBLEM

Cockatoos destroy things. It is normal behavior, not damage, and a bird with nothing sanctioned to destroy will pick your furniture, the cage, or itself. Provide untreated softwood, cardboard, palm and yucca, paper, and cheap consumable toys in constant supply, and treat the whole category as an ongoing running cost. **The good outcome is that everything you provide gets wrecked.** A toy that survives a month has failed.

Dishes, water and the floor

- **Stainless steel dishes**, ideally on swing-out feeders you can service without opening the main door. None of them under a perch
- **Water changed at least daily**, and again whenever it is fouled, which with a bird that dunks food is often twice
- **Plain paper on the tray**, changed daily, so you can read the droppings. Page 28
- **Hard floor under the cage**, or a washable mat. Dust, shredded wood, dropped food and droppings go a surprising distance

WHAT TO LEAVE OUT

No grit: cockatoos hull seed before swallowing and grit causes obstruction. **No happy huts, tents, nest boxes or any dark enclosed cavity**, which are a direct hormonal trigger: page 22. **Nothing galvanized**, and nothing with zinc-plated clips or quick links. **No frayed rope or loose fabric**. And **no toy a beak this strong can reduce to a swallowable fragment** of metal or hard plastic.

BUY THE STAND AT THE SAME TIME AS THE CAGE

Owners routinely buy the cage first and the stand a year later, after the bird has decided the only acceptable place to be is on a person. Having somewhere else that is genuinely good to stand, from week one, is most of the independence problem solved before it starts.

Light, sleep & the 10 to 12 hour rule

In this species, sleep is not a comfort question. It is the cheapest treatment for screaming there is.

A cockatoo needs **10 to 12 hours of genuine darkness and quiet every night**. Not a dim room with the television on in the corner. **Sleep deprivation in this species measurably worsens screaming and other behavioral issues**, and it is one of the more common invisible causes of behavioral problems in pet parrots generally. It is also the first thing to check and the cheapest thing to fix.

BEFORE YOU SPEND MONEY ON A BEHAVIOR PROBLEM, COUNT THE HOURS

A bird living in a family room that stays lit until midnight and wakes with the house at six is getting six hours. That bird will be irritable, loud and prone to plucking, and no toy, no supplement and no consultation fixes it while the sleep debt stands. If the main room cannot go dark and quiet on schedule, the answer is **a separate sleep cage in a quiet room**, moved to at the same time every night. This is standard practice with large parrots, not an extravagance.

Day length is also the hormone lever

Long days signal a breeding season. In a hen that means the laying cycle on page 22; in a cock it means territorial aggression, displaying, and a sharp rise in biting. The routine figure is 10 to 12 hours of darkness. The intervention figure, used under veterinary advice to break a laying cycle, is to **limit light to 8 hours a day**, which is 16 hours of darkness. Both are on page 22.

SETTING	NUMBER
Darkness, normal routine	10 to 12 hours , uninterrupted, at the same times each night
Light, to break a laying cycle	8 hours a day , or LafeberVet's slightly wider 8 to 10. An intervention, under vet advice, not a permanent setting. Merck names a photoperiod over 12 hours as a documented risk factor for excessive laying
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Daylight	Full-spectrum or UV (ultraviolet, the invisible part of sunlight beyond violet) lighting is commonly recommended for indoor parrots, on a timer. Window glass filters most UVB (ultraviolet B), the part of sunlight birds use to make vitamin D3 (cholecalciferol, the form of vitamin D that lets a bird absorb calcium), so a sunny window is a heat trap rather than a light source

The routine, not just the hours

Cockatoos do better on a predictable day than an unpredictable one, and this is doubly true for the anxiety-driven behavior on page 18. A bird that knows when the lights go out, when you leave, when you come back and when the training session happens has far less to be anxious about than one for whom attention arrives at random. Fix the times before you fix anything else.

COVER PARTIALLY, NOT COMPLETELY

A cover on three sides and part of the top gives security while leaving the bird able to see where it is. Blacking a cage out entirely suits some birds and panics others, and there is no way to know which yours is except by trying it and watching. If a bird thrashes in the dark, uncover a side and add a dim night light.

Feather dust, air quality & your own lungs

The page nobody mentions in the shop, and the one that decides whether the household copes.

Cockatoos are powder-down birds. Specialized feathers break down continuously into a fine keratin dust that the bird uses to condition its plumage, and a cockatoo produces a great deal of it. In practice that means **a visible film on every horizontal surface in the room within a day**, dust in electronics, and a haze in a sunbeam. It is not a sign of poor husbandry. It is what the bird is.

BIRD FANCIER'S LUNG

Prolonged exposure to avian proteins in feather dust and dried droppings can cause **hypersensitivity pneumonitis**, known as bird fancier's lung. The NHLBI (National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute, the US government's heart and lung research institute) lists **having pet birds in the home** as a risk factor in its own right, not just occupational exposure, and puts most diagnoses between the ages of **50 and 70**. It presents as breathlessness, a dry cough, and a flu-like illness with fever, chills and aching muscles or joints, with persistent bronchitis and weight loss over a longer course. The serious form is progressive lung fibrosis, and the treatment is steroids plus **removing the exposure**, which for a pet owner can mean rehoming the bird.

This is rare, and it is not a reason not to keep a cockatoo. It *is* a reason to control the dust properly from day one rather than after symptoms start, and a reason to tell your doctor you keep a parrot if you develop an unexplained cough. Anyone in the house who is asthmatic, immunocompromised, or has existing lung disease should weigh this species specifically.

Controlling it, in order of effect

MEASURE	WHAT IT DOES
A HEPA (high-efficiency particulate air) purifier in the bird's room	HEPA is the filter grade that traps fine dust. The single most effective step, and a genuinely practical part of the setup rather than a nice-to-have. Size it for the room and run it continuously. Change the filter on schedule, which is a real running cost
Bathing the bird daily	A wet bird sheds far less dust, and most cockatoos enjoy a shower or a misting. Offer it in the morning so the bird is dry by night. The cheapest control there is
Damp-wiping, never dry dusting	A dry cloth or a feather duster puts the dust back into the air. Damp cloth, damp mop, and a vacuum with a sealed HEPA filter
Hard flooring, not carpet	Carpet under a cockatoo cage becomes a dust reservoir you cannot clean
Not the bedroom	Eight hours a night of concentrated exposure is exactly the pattern that causes problems in people
Ventilation	Fresh air, without putting the cage on a draft. An open window in another room and an internal door ajar works better than pointing a fan at the bird

The dust is also a disease route

PBFD is shed in high concentration in feather dander and dust, which is precisely why a quarantine has to be a **separate room, ideally not on the same air**, and not a corner of the same one. Page 29. It is also why a glossy, flaking or unusually shiny beak matters as a sign in this family: the beak looks that way because the powder down that normally dulls it has failed. Page 25.

BUY THE PURIFIER WITH THE CAGE

Not after the first month, when the dust has already been through the house. It belongs in the setup budget on page 34 alongside the cage and the stand, and it is the piece of equipment cockatoo owners most consistently say they should have bought sooner.

Household hazards & bird-proofing

A bird's lungs make ordinary household air lethal, and this beak reaches things a small parrot cannot.

PTFE: THE ONE THAT KILLS WITH NO WARNING

PTFE, short for polytetrafluoroethylene, is the coating on nonstick pans. Overheated to about **536°F (280°C)**, which an empty or forgotten pan reaches in minutes, it gives off fumes that cause direct caustic damage to the lung, and the Merck Veterinary Manual notes that **acute death is often the only clinical sign**. The fumes travel, so a bird in another room is not safe.

Cookware is not the only source. Merck also lists **irons and ironing board covers, some self-cleaning ovens, heating elements in some reverse-cycle heat pumps, and some heat lamps**. If a bird lives in the house, replace nonstick pans with stainless steel or cast iron, never run an oven's self-clean cycle, and keep the cage out of the kitchen entirely.

HAZARD	WHERE IT IS	WHAT IT DOES
Zinc	Galvanized bar, mesh, chains, quick links, bells, keys, pennies after 1982. A cockatoo chews all of it. Electroplated galvanizing is considered safe; hot-dipped, the commoner kind, leaches zinc with no flake swallowed	Anorexia, gut disease, weakness, regurgitation, excessive drinking and urination. Chelated by a vet, and it clears faster than lead
Lead	Blinds, costume jewelry, mirror backings, some imported toys, hardware cloth, curtain weights, old paint. It tastes sweet, so a bird that finds it keeps chewing	Weight loss, regurgitation, diarrhea, weakness, incoordination, seizures, blindness. Treatable, and worth catching early
Aerosols and smoke	Carpet fresheners, perfumes, deodorizers, candles, plastics melted or burned in a microwave, new heating ducts, tobacco smoke	Irritant to fatal depending on dose. Never spray in the bird's room
Mains cables	Anywhere at beak height	A cockatoo's beak goes through a cable a budgie could not dent. Conduit, cable trunking, or cut the power to the room
Open water	Full sinks, toilets, pans on the stove, uncovered tanks	A wet bird cannot climb out of a smooth basin. Lids down, sinks emptied
Windows and mirrors	Anywhere a flighted bird has a run	Collision injuries. Blinds half drawn during out-of-cage time
The other pets	Cats and dogs	A cat's mouth carries bacteria that kill birds. Any cat contact is a same-day vet visit even with no visible wound
Ceiling fans and hobs	On, during free flight	Both fatal, both avoidable by switching them off first

And the hazard that runs the other way

A large cockatoo can inflict a bite that needs stitches, and it can destroy woodwork, a laptop or a set of blinds in the time it takes to answer the door. Bird-proofing for this species means protecting the room from the bird as much as the bird from the room. Page 17.

THE PRE-FLIGHT CHECK

Windows and doors shut. Blinds partly drawn. Ceiling fan off. Stove off and pans away. Toilet lids down and sinks empty. Other pets out of the room. Candles out. Cables covered. Do it in the same order every time until it is automatic, and do it even on the day you are only letting the bird out for five minutes.

Diet: pellets, seed & converting a seed eater

One ratio worth memorizing, and the disease list that follows from getting it wrong.

The target is **approximately 75 to 80% formulated pellets**, with fresh vegetables making up most of the **remaining 20 to 25%**, fruit a smaller share, and **seed under about 10%**, as a treat rather than the base of the diet. That is the whole prescription.

A SEED-HEAVY DIET IS THE CENTRAL FEEDING MISTAKE IN THIS SPECIES

It leads directly to obesity, fatty liver disease and vitamin A deficiency, and high-fat diets are specifically linked to the **lipomas** that show up so often in overweight cockatoos. Page 26 is the consequence page. Sunflower seeds and peanuts are the worst offenders, and a bird left to choose eats them and leaves everything else, so the diet the bird actually consumes is worse than the one in the bowl.

Portions, which are smaller than they look

VCA (Veterinary Centers of America), a large US chain of veterinary hospitals, offers a mental picture worth keeping: **a small handful of food for a cockatoo is roughly a dinner-plate portion for a person**. Over-portioning is easy and invisible, and it is how a bird on a correct diet still gets fat. Offer fresh food daily, take the fresh part out after about two hours before it spoils, and clean both dishes every day. Fresh water is always available.

Converting a seed eater

Do it gradually, and expect it to take **days, weeks or months**. Nothing here is a hunger strike. Pick one method or run several together:

METHOD	HOW
Morning first	Pellets alone first thing, when the bird is hungriest. Seed goes back in later
Mix and shift	Mix pellets into the seed and reduce the seed share over weeks
Grind it in	Grind pellets to powder over a moist food, then increase the chunk size gradually
Foraged, not offered	This species' particular advantage. A pellet hidden inside a wrapped parcel is worth investigating in a way a pellet in a bowl is not. Page 15
Eat it in front of the bird	Cockatoos are intensely social feeders. Visibly eating the same food yourself converts more birds than any product

Withdraw seed only once the bird is reliably eating pellets and produce, and **weigh it through the change**, on the scale from page 21. A bird losing weight is not converting, it is starving, and that is the only failure mode that matters here.

NO GRIT, AND NO SUPPLEMENTS ON A GOOD DIET

Grit is not needed: cockatoos hull seed before swallowing the kernel, and grit can cause a dangerous digestive blockage. And **a bird eating 75 to 80% pellets does not need added vitamins or minerals**, because the pellet is already fortified; stacking supplements on top can do harm. The exceptions are a bird still transitioning off seed and a laying hen needing calcium, and both are a conversation with your avian vet rather than a jar off a shelf.

WHY THIS SPECIES CAN CONVERT MORE EASILY THAN MOST

Cockatoos are exceptionally curious and exceptionally food-motivated, which is normally a nuisance and here is an asset. A new pellet presented as a puzzle, wrapped in paper or buried in a foraging box, gets investigated. The same pellet in a dish gets ignored. Use the intelligence rather than fighting it.

Safe vegetables, greens & fruit

The 20 to 25% that is not pellets. Vegetables should be most of it and fruit the smaller part.

Vegetables carry the vitamin A that a seed diet lacks, and the rule that does the work is **dark green and dark orange**. Fruit belongs inside the same share rather than on top of it: it is mostly sugar and water, cockatoos adore it, and a bird filling up on mango is a bird not eating kale. Wash everything, cut it to a size a large beak can hold, and remove pits and apple seeds.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Kale, bok choy, chard, dandelion greens	STAPLE	The best of the greens. Offer daily, in a size the bird can hold in a foot
Carrot, in batons	STAPLE	Dense in vitamin A precursors, and a batonet is also something to shred
Bell peppers, any color	STAPLE	Seeds and all. Well accepted by most birds
Broccoli, florets and stalk	STAPLE	Raw or lightly steamed. The stalk is good chewing
Squash, pumpkin, sweet potato	STAPLE	Cooked and cooled. A reliable favorite with birds refusing everything else
Peas, green beans, zucchini, corn on the cob	REGULAR	Well accepted, lower in vitamin A. Corn is high in starch, so treat a cob as an occupation rather than a serving
Cooked pulses, whole grains, cooked pasta	REGULAR	Useful bulk in a chop mix. Nothing salted or seasoned
Papaya, mango, melon, berries, apricot	REGULAR	The vitamin A end of the fruit list. Berries color the droppings red or purple for a day, which is normal. Page 28
Apple, pear, peach, plum, cherry	SPARING	Pits and apple seeds out , because they release cyanide-related compounds. The flesh is fine
Banana, grape, dried fruit	SPARING	High sugar. A piece, not a portion. Check dried fruit for sulfite preservatives
Iceberg lettuce, celery	SKIP	Not toxic, close to nutritionally empty
Onion, garlic, leek, chive	NEVER	Can cause a serious blood disorder in birds. Page 14

The chop, which is how most large-parrot owners actually do this

Batch-prepare a mixed vegetable chop, portion it into containers and freeze it. A week's worth takes half an hour on a Sunday, it solves the "I have no time to chop kale on a Tuesday" problem that quietly ends most fresh-food regimes, and it lets you hide the vegetable a bird refuses among five it accepts. Thaw a portion overnight, serve it in the morning, take it out after two hours.

GETTING A REFUSER TO EAT VEGETABLES

Eat it in front of the bird, obviously and with enthusiasm, from your own plate; this species watches you decide what counts as food. Change the format rather than the food, so a refused chunk gets accepted grated, threaded on a skewer, or woven through the cage bars. Offer it first thing, before the pellet bowl. And keep offering: twenty refusals then acceptance is a normal pattern, not a failure.

Nuts, treats & the never-feed list

The best training currency you have, and the fastest route to a fat bird.

Nuts

A couple of tree nuts a day, almonds, walnuts or Brazil nuts, are a fine daily treat and double as genuine enrichment for a bird this intelligent: an in-shell nut is a puzzle, a shelled one is a snack. Cracking it is most of the value.

The limit is fat. Nuts and sunflower seed are the highest-fat things in the cage, and this species is prone to obesity and to fatty liver. Keep nuts as **the paid reward in a training session**, on page 16, rather than as something in a dish, and you get the training for free and the calories under control. A bird earning one almond in slivers across two sessions is a bird working for its treats.

TREAT	TIER	USE IT FOR
In-shell almond, walnut, Brazil nut	DAILY, COUNTED	The high-value training reward, and a foraging puzzle in itself
Sunflower seed, peanut	SPARING	The highest-fat, lowest-value items in the cage. Fine as an occasional jackpot, never as a diet
Cooked egg, lean meat, a little cheese	SPARING	Useful during a molt or for a laying hen. Nothing processed, salted or seasoned
Whole raw vegetables, corn cobs, palm nuts	ANYTIME	Food that is also work. The best category there is for this species

NEVER, AT ANY QUANTITY

Avocado. Chocolate. Caffeine, including coffee, tea and soft drinks. **Alcohol**. VCA names all four as toxic and potentially fatal. **Onion and garlic**, which can cause a serious blood disorder in birds. **Fruit pits and apple seeds**, which release cyanide-related compounds. **Salt and salted human snacks. Grit or gravel**, which this species has no use for and which can obstruct. And anything sugar-free containing **xylitol**, which has no established safe dose in birds.

THE OVERFED HAND-RAISED BABY

Even on a correct base diet, a cockatoo can be tipped toward obesity by regular calorie-dense treats or by having been overfed as a hand-raised chick. Portion awareness matters even when the food itself is right, and the way to know is the daily weight on page 21, not how the bird looks. A heavily feathered white bird hides a great deal.

TREATS BELONG IN YOUR HAND, NOT IN A DISH

Every treat handed over is a chance to practice a step-up, a target touch, a station, or simply calm behavior being rewarded. Every treat left in a bowl is calories with nothing bought. Over a decade that difference compounds into either a trained, handleable cockatoo or an overweight one that has never had to do anything.

Foraging: filling the gap a bowl leaves

A wild parrot spends much of its day getting food. A full bowl takes minutes. That gap is the problem.

A wild parrot spends **a large share of its waking day** searching for, selecting and manipulating food. A captive bird with a full dish is finished in minutes. That is not a small difference in daily routine, it is most of the bird's waking behavior missing, and something fills the space: in this species it is screaming, destruction and plucking.

The evidence points the same way it does for the training on page 16. **Increased foraging opportunity has repeatedly been found to improve feather condition in parrots**, and in young Amazon parrots foraging opportunity and increased physical complexity both prevented and reduced psychogenic feather picking. It is one of the stronger results in bird welfare.

THE RULE: NOTHING IN A BOWL

Not "some food in toys". Aim for **the whole daily ration delivered through work**, across multiple sites in the cage and the room, so the bird has to search as well as solve. A bowl of pellets in the corner undoes everything else on this page, because a bird that can eat for free will.

How to start, and how to progress

1. **Stage one: visible.** A bird that has only ever been bowl-fed does not know food can be inside a device. Start with food sitting openly on top of a foraging toy, or lightly covered by a single sheet of paper
2. **Stage two: wrapped.** Food in paper parcels, in cardboard tubes, in a paper cup taped shut. Cheap, endless, and destroyed in the process, which is the point
3. **Stage three: contained.** Purpose-made large-parrot foraging toys, rated for a beak this strong, and a foraging box the bird has to dig through
4. **Stage four: distributed.** Several sites, some empty, so the bird searches rather than goes straight to the one place food lives
5. **Then rotate the presentation constantly.** A cockatoo solves a puzzle once and after that it is a container

WATCH INTAKE WHILE YOU MAKE IT HARDER

Do not make the first foraging toy hard. A bird that cannot solve a device eats less rather than working harder, and in a species that is easy to over-condition it is also easy to under-feed by accident. Weigh daily through any change to how food is delivered, and step the difficulty back if the weight moves. Page 21.

Improvised, which is most of it

- Pellets and vegetables inside **paper parcels**, twisted shut, hung from the cage roof
- A **cardboard box** of shredded paper with food buried through it
- Food **threaded on a stainless skewer** between blocks of untreated wood
- Whole vegetables **woven through the bars** so they have to be worked loose
- A **paper cup** taped shut with a nut inside. This costs nothing and occupies a cockatoo for a genuinely useful stretch
- Nuts **in the shell**, which are the original foraging toy

BUDGET DESTRUCTION AS A RUNNING COST

Everything in the list above is consumed. That is the system working, not waste, and it is why the toy line on page 34 is bigger than the food line. Cardboard, paper, untreated softwood and palm are all effectively free, which is what makes a proper foraging routine affordable at this scale.

Training, and why it comes first

The most useful habit in this book, and the one no product can replace.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SUPPORTS

A 2014 study of feather plucking in **sulphur-crested cockatoos** compared haloperidol, socialization, training and feeding enrichment. Its full text is not openly available, so the widely repeated claim that training beat the rest is **not one this book makes**. The accessible review literature lists reinforcement training, environmental enrichment and foraging enrichment together as interventions for feather damaging behavior, with no one of them proven best.

Training still comes first in the routine, because of what a session delivers: **structured time you personally spend with the bird**, the thing a toy left in a cage cannot supply and most owners have least of. Protect the sessions when the week gets busy.

What a session actually looks like

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Length and frequency	VCA's ramp: five to ten minutes, once or twice a day, working up to two twenty-minute sessions once the bird is reliably engaged. Short and often beats long and occasional
Method	Positive reinforcement only: a clicker or marker word and a high-value reward from page 14. Never punishment, restraint, or forcing a bird onto a hand
Stop point	End while the bird still wants more. A session that runs until the bird is bored teaches it that sessions get boring
Where	On a play stand, away from the cage, so the behavior is not tied to territory and the stand becomes a good place to be
Who	Everyone in the household, in rotation. This is how you build a bird with several people rather than one

The behaviors worth teaching, in order

1. **Target touch.** The bird touches its beak to a stick. Everything else is built from it, and it lets you move a large parrot without a hand near its beak
2. **Step up, and step down.** Step down is the one people skip and then need at 10pm
3. **Station.** Go to a named perch and stay there. This is the behavior that gets a bird off your shoulder, out of the kitchen, or away from a visitor
4. **Recall,** for a flighted bird. A safety behavior, and the alternative to a chase
5. **Voluntary crate entry.** A bird that walks into its carrier for a nut is a bird you can take to a vet on a bad night. Page 38
6. **Towel acceptance,** taught slowly with rewards, so restraint at the vet is not a fight
7. **Simple problem solving and novel objects,** once the basics are solid

REWARD CALM, DELIBERATELY, EVERY DAY

The single most useful thing to reinforce is not a trick. It is the bird sitting quietly on its stand doing something of its own. Walk past, drop a reward, say nothing, walk on. Do that fifty times and you have paid for the behavior you actually want, which is a cockatoo that can be near you without needing to be on you. Page 18.

WHAT TRAINING IS NOT

It is not a substitute for the hours out of the cage, the foraging, or the sleep. And it is not a fix applied after a problem starts: established plucking is much harder to reverse than to prevent. Start the sessions in week one, on a bird with no problems at all.

Handling, step-up, bites & sexual maturity

Including the change at five to seven years old that catches owners of a sweet bird completely off guard.

The mechanics

- **Offer a forearm or a flat hand**, not a single finger, and let the bird choose to step
- **A handheld perch** is standard practice with a bird that bites, and using one is not a failure. Target training on page 16 keeps hands away from the beak
- **Never force it.** A hand pushed at a cockatoo's chest is a hand it learns to bite. If the bird will not step up, something is wrong with the moment, not with the bird
- **Never chase a loose bird**, and never grab one. Both cost trust that takes months to rebuild

HEAD AND NECK ONLY

Stroking the back, under the wings, or anywhere near the vent mimics a mate. In a cockatoo it triggers hormonal behavior, which drives both the aggression on this page and the egg problems on page 22, and it is one of the classic first-timer mistakes. This applies to cocks as well as hens, and it applies to the cuddling this species is bought for. **Scratch the head. Leave the body alone.**

Bites

Large cockatoos bite more readily and with less restraint than many other parrots, and a bite from a bird this size can require stitches. That is a reason to read the bird, not to fear it. Almost every bite follows a warning that was missed.

SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS
Crest raised sharply and held forward, body rigid	Alarm or threat. Stop moving toward the bird
Eye pinning, pupils flashing wide and narrow	High arousal. It can be excitement or aggression, and next to a raised crest it is a warning
Beak open, head lowered, feathers up on the neck	Committed threat. Back away
Lunging at the bars as you approach the cage	Cage territoriality. Work with the bird outside the cage instead
Crest relaxed, feathers smooth, body loose	Calm. Carry on
Beak grinding, one foot up, half-closed eyes	Contentment, usually before sleep

SEXUAL MATURITY: 3 TO 4 YEARS, OR 5 TO 6 IN THE LARGE SPECIES

Aggression often increases sharply at sexual maturity, and it catches owners of a previously sweet, cuddly bird completely off guard. A hand-raised cockatoo that has been a lap animal for five years can become territorial, hormonal and genuinely dangerous to the person it is not bonded to. Nothing has gone wrong and the bird is not broken; it has grown up.

What helps: hold the photoperiod at 10 to 12 hours of darkness (page 9), stop all body petting, remove every cavity, keep training sessions running through it, and make sure the bird has independent occupation. What does not help is punishment, or withdrawing from the bird, which makes the following year worse.

IF YOU ARE BITTEN

Do not shout, fling the bird off, or react dramatically. Any big reaction is interesting, and interesting is a reward. Put the bird calmly on a perch, walk away, and work out afterwards which warning you missed. Then clean the wound and see a doctor if it is deep, because this is a puncture wound.

Over-bonding, separation anxiety & independence

The defining problem of this species, and it is created in the first few weeks by owners doing what feels loving.

Cockatoos form unusually intense bonds with their people. In the wild they maintain near-constant physical contact with a mate and a flock, and that trait carries straight into a house as an expectation of the same from you. This is why they are described as velcro birds, and why a cockatoo that gets what it needs can be an extraordinary companion. It is also why the failure mode is so severe: an over-bonded cockatoo develops **genuine separation anxiety when left alone, even briefly**, and screams and plucks when the person it has chosen leaves the room.

THE BIGGEST FIRST-TIMER MISTAKE

Over-bonding early on. Spending intense one-on-one time in the first weeks, because the bird is new and adorable and available, cements an anxious dependency rather than a healthy attachment. The bird learns that constant contact with one person is the normal state of the world, and then everything that is not that becomes distress. What feels like the most loving possible start is the thing that produces the screaming at year two.

Building independence, from day one

PRACTICE	WHY
Several people, in rotation	Feeding, training and out-of-cage time shared across the household. A bird with four people has four sources of company and does not collapse when one goes to work. The highest-leverage habit here
Reward self-directed activity	Walk past, drop a reward when the bird is playing on its own, say nothing, walk on. You are paying for exactly the behavior you want
Leave the room constantly, briefly	Out for ten seconds, back. Out for a minute, back. Departures become unremarkable because they happen forty times a day and nothing bad follows
A stand that is genuinely good to be on	Food, foraging and things to destroy live there. Somewhere to be that is not your shoulder. Page 8
Not the only stimulation	Radio, a view, foraging, a routine. A bird whose entire day is you has one point of failure
Low-key departures and returns	An emotional goodbye teaches the bird that your leaving is significant. It should be the least interesting thing that happens all day

The shoulder question

A cockatoo on a shoulder is next to your face and out of your sight, and this is a beak that can take a stitch-requiring bite without meaning much by it. It also puts the bird physically level with you, which for a species this hormonal is not a neutral position. Many experienced keepers of large parrots simply do not do shoulders, and work from the hand, the forearm and a stand instead. If yours already rides on your shoulder, teach the station cue on page 16 so you can end it politely.

IF THE BIRD IS ALREADY OVER-BONDED

It is retrievable and it is slow. Widen the circle gradually: have the second person do the feeding and the training while the primary person is out of the room, reward calm separation in very small increments, and keep the schedule predictable so attention is not something the bird has to demand. If it escalates over several weeks of consistent effort, get a certified avian behavior consultant involved rather than trying harder. This is the exact problem they exist for.

Screaming, noise & the household reality

Some of it is normal and permanent. The rest is a message, and there is a specific way to answer it.

In the wild, cockatoos use loud, far-carrying contact calls to locate flock members across dense canopy. It is a functional communication tool, not noise for its own sake, and it does not switch off because the bird lives indoors. A cockatoo separated from its flock, which is your household, in another room, or one whose social needs are not being met through the day, escalates contact calling because that is precisely what it evolved to do when isolated.

WHAT IS NORMAL AND WILL NOT CHANGE

Brief bouts of loud contact calling around dawn and dusk are normal cockatoo behavior, mirroring when wild flocks are most vocal. Accept it. Cockatoos are loud by design and quieting one is not an achievable goal, only a source of frustration for both of you. What is *not* normal is prolonged, escalating screaming through the day, and that usually signals unmet social or enrichment needs rather than a fixed habit.

What actually works, and what makes it worse

APPROACH	EFFECT
Ignoring the bird when it is calm, responding when it screams	Makes it worse. The bird has no reliable way to get attention except escalating
Yelling back, or reacting loudly	Makes it worse. Any reliable response, including an annoyed one, registers as the call working
Covering the cage as a punishment	Makes it worse , and it damages the sleep routine that is helping. Page 9
Rewarding quiet or calmer vocalizations with attention	Works. Teaches the bird that softer sounds also get a response. Answer the whistles and the talk, not the scream
Consistent daily interaction, scheduled in advance	Works. Reduces the anxiety-driven escalation that comes from unpredictable attention
A contact call of your own, answered from another room	Works. Whistle back. The bird wants to know where the flock is, and a two-second answer often ends it

The pattern across almost every case is **proactive engagement rather than reactive discipline**. Predictable, generous attention on a schedule removes the pressure that builds into screaming, and it is much easier than trying to extinguish it afterwards.

Before you treat it as behavioral

A sudden change in a previously stable bird's vocal or behavioral pattern **can signal underlying pain or illness**. Any real change in behavior is worth a vet visit to rule that out, and that is true here as much as it is for plucking on page 24.

NOISE IS A HOUSING DECISION, AND IT IS WORTH BEING HONEST ABOUT

A cockatoo scream carries through walls. Renting with one is difficult, an attached home means your neighbors are part of this decision, and noise is one of the commonest reasons a cockatoo is rehomed. There is no soundproofing that solves it and no training that removes it. If a noise complaint would cost you your home, this is the wrong bird, and page 5 would rather you found that out now.

Wing clipping & flight

You will be asked in week one, usually by whoever is selling the trim. Here is both sides, honestly.

Wing clipping means shortening some primary flight feathers so the bird cannot gain height. It is not permanent: cut feathers are dead structures and are replaced at the next molt, so a clip lasts one molt cycle. It is also **not a behavior tool**. A clipped cockatoo is not tamer, calmer, quieter or less hormonal than a flighted one, and clipping does not reduce screaming, plucking or biting. It is a bird that cannot fly.

THE CASE FOR CLIPPING	THE CASE AGAINST
Removes the escape risk from an open door in a house of several people	The same risk is removed by closing the door. A clipped bird caught by wind outdoors can still travel, and it cannot fly back
Removes the collision risk with windows and mirrors in a new home	Flight is this bird's main exercise, and a heavy species that cannot fly gains weight. Obesity, lipomas and fatty liver are all on page 26
Makes early handling of an unfamiliar adult bird more manageable	Handling built on a bird that cannot leave is compliance, not trust. Page 16 builds the real thing, and it works on a flighted bird
Reduces the risk in a house with a stove, a dog or small children	A clipped cockatoo lands hard. Keel and leg injuries from bad landings are common, especially on hard floors, and this is a heavy bird

BLOOD FEATHERS, AND WHY THIS IS NOT A HAIRCUT

A growing feather has a live blood supply in its shaft and looks dark and full at the base. **Cut one and it bleeds**, and on a large parrot it can bleed a great deal. Only fully mature feathers are ever trimmed, and knowing the difference is the entire skill. Merck's method is four to seven of the outermost primaries on both wings, cut below the coverts that overlay them, with the secondaries closer to the body left alone, because those are what let a bird slow down and land. If a bird is clipped, an avian vet or an experienced groomer does it and you watch. Never attempt a first clip yourself from a video, and never clip a bird that is molting.

If it is done, what a correct clip leaves

A correct trim leaves the bird able to glide down to the floor under control from a standing perch, symmetrically on both wings so it does not spiral into a wall. It does not leave a bird that drops like a stone, and it never removes every primary. On a bird this heavy, an over-clip is genuinely dangerous. Ask for a light, symmetrical trim, and watch the bird land before you leave the clinic.

The honest recommendation

For a household that can properly proof a room, a **flighted cockatoo is the better outcome**, and the work goes into the pre-flight check on page 11 rather than into the bird. The exercise matters more in a large heavy parrot than in a small one, and a recall trained per page 16 solves most of what clipping is meant to solve. Clipping is defensible in a specific, temporary situation, and in those cases it is a decision to revisit at the next molt rather than a standing policy.

TRAIN THE RECALL EITHER WAY

A cockatoo that comes to your hand on cue is safer than a clipped one, because you can retrieve it from anywhere in the room without a chase. A nut, a short distance, a consistent cue, twice a day. Alongside the station cue, it is the most useful pair of behaviors in this book.

Sexing, weight & body condition

The iris trick that works in most white cockatoos, and the number to track daily.

Sexing

In most of the white *Cacatua* species, including the umbrella and the Moluccan, mature birds can often be told apart by **iris color**: the male's is very dark brown to black, the female's a reddish or chestnut brown, most visible in good light. It is a useful field feature, and it is not reliable in every bird, species or lighting condition.

LafeberVet gives the reason it fails in a young bird: **immature cockatoos have a pale gray iris**, so the cue simply is not there yet.

Where it matters, and it matters for everything on page 22, **a DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid, the genetic code in every cell) test on a blood spot or a plucked feather is the actual answer**, and it costs a fraction of one vet visit. Do not make a breeding, pairing or hormone-management decision on iris color alone.

It matters because a hen can lay without a mate, and chronic laying is serious, expensive and preventable. An owner who assumes their bird is a cock is an owner who does not recognize a laying cycle starting. Page 22.

Weight is the vital sign

A bird hides illness until it cannot, but it cannot hide a falling weight, and a heavily feathered white cockatoo hides body condition better than almost any bird kept. A **digital scale reading in 1 g steps**, with a perch fixed to it, is the most useful equipment in the house. Weigh at the same time each day, before the first feed, and log it on page 40. Lafeber's Susan Orosz is specific: a scale reading grams rather than ounces, used daily, with the number written down, because it is the chart rather than any single reading that shows a trend.

READING	WHAT IT MEANS
Goffin's about 350 g; umbrella 400 to 700 g; Moluccan and greater sulphur-crested up to about 880 g	The published ranges. Your own bird's stable number matters far more than where it falls in them
Day-to-day variation of a few grams	Normal
A steady fall across three weighings	Investigate. In a converting bird, the conversion is failing. In a settled bird, it is a vet call
Roughly 10% below baseline	Call the vet. In a 600 g bird that is 60 g, which is a great deal of muscle
Roughly 20% above ideal	Merck's working definition of obesity in a bird. Page 26

Feeling the keel

The keel is the ridge of breastbone running down the front of the bird. Rest a finger either side of it during a head scratch, weekly, so you know what your own bird feels like.

- **Sharp and prominent, muscle falling away either side:** underweight, and in this species usually a sick bird rather than an underfed one
- **Ridge easily felt, muscle rounded and full to each side:** what you want
- **Keel hard to find, chest convex, a groove down the center:** overweight, and you may also feel or see fat pads over the abdomen. Diet and flight, never a crash diet

DO NOT CRASH-DIET A FAT COCKATOO

Rapid weight loss mobilizes fat into a liver already under strain and can kill the bird. Weight reduction is a supervised, months-long project run with an avian vet: the correct pellet share, more vegetables, fewer nuts, far more exercise. Page 26.

ESTABLISH THE BASELINE IN THE FIRST MONTH

Weigh daily for the first two weeks and record it. Those two weeks of numbers make every later reading readable, and it is what owners wish they had when something looks slightly off in year six.

Hens, hormones & chronic egg laying

A hen lays because the environment told her to. Every lever on this page is one you control.

A cockatoo hen will lay with no male present. She does it because something in her environment reads as a breeding season, and every clutch costs her calcium she draws out of her own skeleton. **Chronic egg laying**, clutch after clutch out of season, ends in depletion, weakness and egg binding. Hormonal behavior in a cock is the same physiology producing aggression, displaying and biting instead, and it responds to the same levers.

The trigger list, and what to do about each

TRIGGER	REMOVE IT
Long days	The main lever. 10 to 12 hours of darkness normally; to break a cycle, limit light to 8 hours a day under vet advice. Page 9
Any dark enclosed cavity	Happy hut, tent, nest box, cardboard box, a cupboard she found, the space behind the sofa. All of it, including the snuggly things sold for cockatoos
Petting the back, wings or vent	Head and neck only, by everyone in the house. The hardest change to make in a species bought for cuddling, and the most important. Page 17
A mirror, or a bonded toy	Out. To a lone bird a mirror is a mate
Soft nesting material and paper shredding	Restrict shredding during a hormonal period, and keep the tray liner out of reach
Rich, abundant, constant food	Plenty reads as a good season. Measure portions, keep nuts rare, and move food into foraging. Page 15
A static territory	Moving the cage and rearranging perches disrupts a site she has decided is a nest

DO NOT REMOVE THE EGGS AS SHE LAYS THEM

Pulling each egg tells the hen the clutch has failed and she lays a replacement, which is exactly how chronic laying starts. **Leave the clutch and let her sit.** A cockatoo clutch is typically 3 to 4 eggs and incubation runs 23 to 30 days, so a hen allowed to sit usually gives up after a few weeks and stops. Swap real eggs for dummy eggs if you are worried about them spoiling. Sitting on a clutch costs her far less than laying three more.

Egg binding, which is the emergency

A hen unable to pass an egg is a same-day emergency, not something to monitor. Signs, roughly in order: weakness and sitting low rather than perching; **straining** as if to pass a dropping, repeatedly and with nothing produced; a swollen or firm lower abdomen; fluffed feathers, wide stance and labored breathing; sometimes an egg visible at the vent or tissue prolapsing; and in late cases **leg weakness or paralysis** from the egg pressing on the nerves. VCA adds a marker that stands on its own before the rest of that list appears: **no egg passed in 48 hours** by a hen you know is laying.

The causes are low calcium above everything else, because calcium is what makes the oviduct contract, plus obesity and inactivity, chronic laying, a first or an elderly clutch, and an oversized or misshapen egg. Seed diets are deficient in calcium, selenium, and vitamins D and E, which is why this page runs back to page 12. Treatment is supplemental heat, fluids, calcium and vitamin D3, then oxytocin, then manual or surgical removal.

Meanwhile: carrier, dark and quiet, warmed to **75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C)**, toward the upper end, where a sick bird eats and recovers best. Back off at flat sleek feathers, wings held out or open-mouth breathing, which mean too hot. Never massage the abdomen or pull at a visible egg.

SUPPORT A LAYING HEN, AND KNOW WHEN TO ASK FOR MORE

Cuttlebone and a mineral block permanently available; a pellet diet carrying vitamin D3 so the calcium can be used; extra protein while laying; daily weighing. If she keeps laying after every environmental lever has been pulled, that is a veterinary conversation, not another month of adjustments. Hormone therapy by injection or implant exists for exactly this, and it is better used before she is depleted than after the first emergency.

Health red flags & what to tell the vet

A bird that looks sick has been sick for a while. Under all that white feather, longer than usual.

Birds mask illness because in a flock a predator picks the weakest-looking animal. A large, densely feathered white cockatoo hides it particularly well, which is why the daily weight on page 21 and the droppings check on page 28 matter more here than looking at the bird does.

SAME-DAY CALL, NO WAITING

Any **difficulty breathing**: tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, clicking or wheezing, or a change in voice. **Bleeding** from anywhere, including a broken blood feather, which on a bird this size can lose real volume. **Sitting on the cage floor** instead of perching. **Straining** in a hen: page 22. **Discharge** from eyes, nostrils or mouth. Fluffed and unresponsive with both feet down. Seizures, one-sided weakness, or sudden collapse. A fall, a burn, a cat contact of any kind, or a suspected PTFE exposure.

Call within 24 hours

- A sustained drop in appetite, especially alongside anything else here
- Any change in droppings that persists beyond about 24 hours. Page 28
- Weight down roughly 10% from the bird's own baseline
- New feather damage, bald patches, or obsessive preening of one area. Page 24
- Feathers coming in stunted, clubbed or pinched, or a beak that has gone glossy, flaky or overgrown. Page 25
- Lameness, or unwillingness to bear weight on one leg
- **A sudden change in vocal or behavioral pattern in a previously stable bird**, which can signal pain or illness rather than an emotional cause
- Vomiting, which sticks to the face and chest feathers, as distinct from deliberate courtship regurgitation onto a toy or a hand

The normal numbers, for reference

MEASURE	NORMAL IN A LARGE COCKATOO
Body temperature	About 106.2°F (41.2°C). Not something to take at home
Resting heart rate	Scales with size: about 147 bpm in a 500 g bird, about 127 in a 1,000 g bird
Respiratory rate	15 to 40 breaths a minute at rest, with no tail movement
Weight	Species-dependent. Track your own bird's baseline. Page 21

What to tell the vet, written down before you call

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Today's weight, and the baseline from page 40 | ☐ Whether it is a hen, and whether it has ever laid |
| ☐ Exactly what the bird eats, by share, not by brand | ☐ Any new bird, new house, new person or new routine |
| ☐ When the signs started, and what changed that week | ☐ Nonstick cookware, candles, aerosols, or new cage hardware |
| ☐ Hours of darkness it actually gets | ☐ A photo of the droppings on the paper liner |

FIND THE VET BEFORE YOU NEED ONE, AND CHECK THEY TAKE THIS SPECIES

Avian practice is a specialty, and not every avian vet is set up for a bird that can take a finger off. Call in week one, ask specifically about large cockatoos, ask what their after-hours arrangement is, and write both numbers on page 33. Add a certified avian behavior consultant to the same card while you are at it.

Feather-destructive behavior, molt & the differential

Particularly prevalent in this species, more so than in most other parrots. And it is a medical question first.

A VET VISIT COMES FIRST, EVERY TIME

Medical triggers including *Giardia* and Pbfd can cause plucking, and a bird in pain from an internal problem plucks over the site. Assuming a behavioral cause before an avian vet has ruled out a medical one is the commonest and costliest mistake made with this species. Fix a real medical cause and the behavior often stops; rearrange the cage instead and you lose months.

The three-way differential owners get wrong

WHAT IT IS	WHAT YOU SEE
Normal molt	Symmetrical, staggered, matching feathers on each wing, new feathers pushing up before the old drop, whole feathers found intact on the floor, head included , and the bird otherwise well. Merck's picture is a full molt at least once a year, with many birds also running a smaller partial molt about six months after. A molting cockatoo is quieter, hungrier, touchier, and covered in sore pin feathers. Bathe more, handle less, offer more protein
Feather-destructive behavior	Asymmetrical, confined to where the bird can reach, head feathers untouched , chewed or snapped shafts left behind. Over-preening to bare skin, and in serious cases self-mutilation of the skin itself
Pbfd	Feathers coming in <i>wrong</i> rather than falling out: stunted, club-shaped or pinched off, worsening at each successive molt, often with a glossy or flaking beak. Page 25

A bird that has lost head feathers has not plucked them, because it cannot reach. That single observation separates disease from behavior faster than anything else, and it is the first thing to check.

Once medical causes are excluded

The behavioral drivers are stress, boredom, loneliness, separation anxiety, and poor early socialization, and management means addressing the underlying social and emotional needs rather than treating the symptom. In rough order of value:

1. **Daily training sessions.** Structured attention, the part no toy supplies. Page 16
2. **All food through foraging**, across multiple sites. Increased foraging opportunity repeatedly improves feather condition in parrots. Page 15
3. **Constant destructible material.** A bird with nothing sanctioned to destroy destroys itself. Page 8
4. **Sleep.** Count the actual hours of dark. Page 9
5. **Independence work**, if the plucking follows the primary person leaving the room. Page 18
6. **A predictable routine**, because unpredictable attention is itself a stressor
7. **Bathing**, offered daily, which also helps the dust on page 10

CATCH IT EARLY, BECAUSE ESTABLISHED PLUCKING IS DIFFERENT

Once established, plucking becomes **self-soothing and habitual and can continue after the original cause is resolved**, which is why prevention is disproportionately more effective than treatment. Watch for time spent preening one area beyond normal grooming, small bald patches on the chest or under the wings developing gradually, and any increase in agitation that coincides with a change in routine, a move, or reduced attention. Act at those, not at the bald patch.

WHEN TO BRING IN A BEHAVIORIST

If it escalates after several weeks of consistent change, or if the bird has broken skin or drawn blood, do two things in parallel: an avian vet visit to rule out a medical cause, and a referral to a certified avian behaviorist once the bird is cleared. Behaviorists work with entrenched cases far more effectively than general advice can, and waiting makes the behavior more deeply ingrained.

PBFD & viral disease

First described in Australian cockatoos, incurable, and the reason page 29 exists.

Psittacine beak and feather disease is caused by a circovirus and affects **over 50 species of bird**, concentrated in parrots from Australia, Africa, New Zealand and Indonesia, which puts every cockatoo squarely in the susceptible group. It was first described in Australian cockatoos, and **white cockatoo species are specifically noted for the beak malformations it causes**. It is rare in New World parrots such as macaws, amazons and conures. Infection can occur at any age but is most common in birds under three years old.

FORM	WHO	WHAT HAPPENS
Peracute	Newly hatched chicks	Death, often before any feather sign
Acute	Young birds growing their first feathers	Rapid, severe feather abnormality during that development
Chronic	Older birds	Progressive abnormality worsening at each successive molt. This is how most owners meet it

Signs

- **Feathers** that come in stunted, club-shaped or pinched off at the shaft, with premature molting and eventually bald areas
- **Loss of the normal powder down**, which is why **a glossy-looking beak is a sign**. In a healthy cockatoo the powder down dusts and dulls the beak; when the virus destroys the cells producing it, the beak shines. Page 10
- **Beak deformity**: in cockatoos, elongated, excessively flaky or shiny, and breaking easily
- In African greys, by contrast, generalized sickness and anemia with no feather or beak signs at all, which is worth knowing if you keep both

THERE IS NO TREATMENT AND NO CURE

Most affected birds die of secondary infections within months to years. Transmission is through the mouth, nose or cloaca, and the virus is shed heavily in droppings, crop secretions and **feather dust**, which is exactly why quarantine has to mean separate air rather than a separate corner. Incubation runs from **weeks to years**, so a bird can look perfectly well and be shedding. Diagnosis is a blood test or an oral swab for the viral DNA, or a skin and feather biopsy.

Avian polyomavirus

The second virus a quarantine panel is designed to catch. It is most associated with budgerigars, where it is called budgerigar fledgling disease, but it infects other psittacines including cockatoos. The dangerous form is in unweaned chicks, causing crop stasis, hemorrhage under the skin and death within a day or two, so it is largely a breeder and shop problem rather than a threat to a settled adult. A vaccine exists and is used in aviaries. Its relevance to a pet buyer is the same as PBFD's: it is on the panel, and it is a reason not to buy from a place with sick birds in the next cage.

WHAT PREVENTION ACTUALLY IS

Quarantine any new bird before it meets an established one, and test rather than merely wait. That is genuinely important prevention rather than excessive caution, and it is the only control available for a disease with no treatment. Page 29 is the procedure.

Obesity, lipomas & fatty liver

One cause, three diagnoses, and all of them run back to the food bowl.

Obesity

Merck's working figure for obesity in a bird is roughly **20% over ideal weight**, and Merck names **galahs**, alongside macaws, Amazons and Quaker parrots, as species prone to it. That is a cockatoo on the list. Fat accumulating in the abdomen presses on the air sacs, so the presenting complaint is often **breathlessness after mild exertion, or lameness**, rather than anything an owner would call a weight problem. Under a thick white plumage you will not see it. You will see it on the scale. Page 21.

Lipomas

Benign fatty tumors, **common in overweight cockatoos and tied directly to high-fat, seed-heavy diets**. They typically appear as soft masses on the chest or abdomen. Birds actually eating their pellets develop them far less often. Management is veterinary guidance plus genuine diet correction, and surgical removal is sometimes needed when a mass interferes with movement, but the diet is the actual treatment.

Hepatic lipidosis

Fatty liver disease, from the same seed-heavy overfeeding pattern. It is quiet for a long time and then it is not.

SIGN	DETAIL
Beak and nail keratin changes	Overgrown, soft, flaking or oddly colored. A genuinely useful early sign because you can see it during a head scratch, and one worth checking weekly
Enlarged liver	Found by your vet, sometimes visible as abdominal distension
Labored breathing	From abdominal pressure on the air sacs
Poor feather quality	Which is also, confusingly, on the plucking and PBFD lists. Page 24
Green staining in the urates	Bile pigment. Page 28

DO NOT CRASH-DIET A FAT BIRD

Rapid weight loss mobilizes fat into a liver that is already struggling and can kill the bird. Weight reduction in a parrot is a supervised project run over months with an avian vet: correct the pellet share, increase vegetables, cut nuts and seed to earned training rewards, and add real exercise through flight and out-of-cage time. It is slow on purpose.

VITAMIN A DEFICIENCY BELONGS ON THE SAME PAGE

The other consequence of a seed diet, and the commonest nutritional disease in pet birds. Merck notes that even a diet of half seed and half pellets leaves a bird deficient. It shows as nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eye, white plaques in the mouth, poor feather quality, feather picking and excessive drinking, and it weakens the airway lining, which is why so many respiratory cases on page 27 are nutritional underneath.

THE WHOLE PREVENTION PLAN, IN ONE LINE

Pellets at 75 to 80%, dark vegetables daily, nuts as earned training rewards rather than a bowl item, portions measured against a small handful, hours of flight and climbing, and a weight written down every day. Everything on this page is downstream of that.

Psittacosis, respiratory disease, metals & injuries

The rest of the health section, including the one that passes to people.

Breathing trouble is always urgent

A bird's respiratory system has very little reserve, and there is no mild version of avian breathing difficulty. Learn what normal looks like while the bird is well: **15 to 40 breaths a minute at rest, with the tail perfectly still.** Tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, a clicking or rasping sound, a change or loss of voice, discharge at the nostrils, or sitting fluffed with the neck stretched up are all same-day signs.

Psittacosis

Avian chlamydiosis, caused by *Chlamydia psittaci*, and it is zoonotic. A bird can carry it with no signs at all, shedding it in droppings and respiratory secretions, which is why a new bird is tested rather than trusted. When it shows, expect respiratory signs, diarrhea, weakness, an enlarged liver, and lime-green droppings as the classic pointer. Treatment is doxycycline: **45 days has historically been the recommendation**, with shorter courses of 21 to 30 days also potentially effective. Finish the course, because a partial one produces a carrier.

IN PEOPLE

Illness typically begins **5 to 14 days** after exposure, with an abrupt fever, chills, headache, malaise and muscle aches, and a dry cough that can come with breathlessness or chest tightness. It responds to antibiotics. **If anyone in the house develops a flu-like illness with a dry cough and there is a sick bird at home, tell the doctor there is a bird.** They will not think of it. Page 10 covers the separate, non-infectious lung problem this species can cause.

The rest, briefly

CONDITION	WHAT TO KNOW
Heavy metal poisoning	Zinc from galvanized bar, mesh, clips and bells; lead from blinds, curtain weights, mirror backings and old paint. Signs are weight loss, regurgitation, diarrhea, weakness, excessive drinking and, in bad cases, seizures. Both treatable by chelation. Page 11
Aspergillosis	A fungal airway infection favored by damp bedding, poor ventilation and a stressed bird. Slow, insidious and hard to treat once established. Ventilation and a clean cage are the prevention
Giardia	An intestinal protozoal parasite that can cause loose stools or intense itching, and a secondary feather-destructive habit that looks entirely behavioral. A fecal test belongs in any plucking work-up. Page 24
Candida	A yeast overgrowth, common after antibiotics or on a poor diet. Regurgitation, weight loss, diarrhea, reduced appetite. Treatable
Broken blood feather	Bleeds freely when snapped, and on this size of bird the volume matters. Firm, steady pressure with clean gauze, styptic powder or cornstarch on the exposed broken tip, never into an open follicle . Vet at two to three minutes. Do not pull it: VCA does not recommend pulling one at home, and even in clinic it is a last resort
Overgrown beak	Not a grooming failure. It points at liver disease, mites or trauma, and wants a vet rather than a trim. Page 26
Bumblefoot	Pressure sores under the foot, from identical perches, obesity or a dirty cage. A heavy bird is at more risk. Page 8 prevents it
Cat or dog contact	A cat's mouth carries <i>Pasteurella</i> , which can turn septic within hours, from a wound too small to find. Any cat contact is a same-day vet visit for antibiotics, even if the bird seems fine

THE FIRST-AID KIT, IN A LABELED BOX

Cornstarch or styptic powder, sterile gauze, blunt-tipped scissors, a large towel, a travel carrier, a controllable heat source, saline, and the vet's number taped to the lid. Assemble it in week one, where anyone can find it in the dark.

Reading droppings & hydration

The cheapest daily health check you own, and the reason the tray is lined with plain paper.

A bird dropping has **three components**, and telling them apart is the whole skill. The **feces** is the solid, formed, coiled part. The **urates** are the chalky white part, uric acid crystals that let a bird excrete nitrogen using almost no water. The **urine** is the clear liquid halo around the outside. Each can change independently, and which one changed tells you where the problem is.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Green feces , formed, in a seed-fed bird	Normal. Diet colors the fecal part, and seed-eating birds pass green feces
Brown feces , formed, in a pellet-fed bird	Normal. Expect the color to change during a diet conversion and do not panic at it
Red, pink or purple	Almost always berries or beetroot, and it lasts a day. If the bird has eaten nothing colored, it is blood, and it is a same-day call
Lime green or yellow-green	A liver pointer, and a classic sign of chlamydiosis. Page 27. Vet
Black or tarry	Digested blood from higher in the gut. Vet, today
Yellow or green urates	The white part should be white. Colored urates point at the liver. Page 26
Watery, but the feces still formed	Polyuria , excess urine, not diarrhea. Usually a watery meal, sometimes stress. Persisting with minimal fruit over 24 hours raises kidney disease, and VCA notes polyuria is often the first sign of kidney damage from zinc. Page 11
Unformed feces, no solid part	True diarrhea , much less common than owners think and much more serious. Vet
Undigested food in the dropping	Food passing through unabsorbed. Always abnormal, and Merck lists whole seed in the droppings as a sign of avian gastric yeast, where a bird keeps eating and still loses weight. Vet, and weigh the bird
Far fewer droppings than yesterday	The bird is not eating, or is obstructed. Both matter. Page 23

THE 24-HOUR RULE

Learn your own bird's normal droppings, because once you know them anything else is abnormal by definition. A single odd dropping is not an emergency; you changed the food, or it ate a blueberry. **Droppings that stay abnormal for more than about 24 hours are a vet visit.** Photograph the paper before you throw it away and take the photo with you.

Hydration

A dehydrated bird has dry, tacky mouth tissue, dull sunken eyes, skin over the keel that stays tented when gently lifted, and urates that go thick and yellow. A large parrot on a pellet diet drinks noticeably more than one eating a lot of fresh food, so a change in water consumption is only meaningful against what that bird normally does. Change the water daily as a minimum, and again whenever it is fouled, which with a bird that dunks food is often twice.

LINE THE TRAY SO YOU CAN READ IT

Plain paper, changed daily, with the grate out if the bird will not stand on the tray. Corncob, sand and wood chip all hide droppings, absorb them, and grow mold underneath, which turns the most informative surface in the cage into the least. It also makes it much harder to notice the day the droppings stop.

Quarantine & adding a second bird

Skipping quarantine is how PBFD spreads. It is also the only control there is.

A new bird can carry PBFD, polyomavirus or chlamydia with no visible sign at all, shedding all three in droppings, crop secretions and **feather dust**. Quarantine is not about whether the new bird looks well. It looks well precisely because that is how these diseases work, and PBFD's incubation runs from weeks to years.

30 TO 45 DAYS, AND TEST

Public health guidance for birds exposed to other birds at shows, sales or events is to quarantine **at least 30 days and test before returning or adding them to a group**. Take that as the floor, and plan on 30 to 45 days in a separate room while the bird is screened. In a household with an existing bird, Merck's figure for introducing a bird to an aviary or an established group is **90 days** with testing, because an infected adult can shed polyomavirus intermittently for up to 90 days before clearing it.

How to actually run it

RULE	WHY
A separate room , ideally not on the same air handling	The rule that matters most for a cockatoo: feather dust is the transmission route and this family produces more of it than anything else kept. A different floor beats a different corner. Page 10
Separate dishes, tools and cleaning cloths	Cross-contamination is usually a bucket or a sponge, not the birds
Established birds first, new bird last	The whole daily routine for the resident bird before you go near the new one, every day, without exceptions
Wash hands and change your shirt	Feather dust sits on clothing. This is the step people skip
A vet exam and a PCR panel in week one	A PCR (polymerase chain reaction) test, a lab test that detects a disease's DNA, for PBFD, polyomavirus and chlamydia. This is what the quarantine is <i>for</i> ; without testing it is just waiting
Weigh the new bird daily	You are looking for the thing it is hiding. Page 21

Then the introduction

1. **Cages in sight of each other, several feet apart**, for at least a week. Let them see and call with no contact
2. **Move them closer** gradually, watching for interest rather than lunging at the bars
3. **Neutral ground first**. The first physical meeting happens on a play stand or a table, never inside either cage. A cockatoo defends its cage hard and a bite from this beak lands differently between birds than between budgies
4. **Short supervised sessions**, extended as they get boring. Normal negotiation is beak fencing, chasing and noise; a real fight is one bird pinning another or gripping a foot. Separate for that, not the noise
5. **Separate cages permanently** is the default with large cockatoos. Two birds who live beside each other and call back and forth get most of the social benefit with none of the risk

A SECOND COCKATOO IS NOT A SOLUTION TO THE FIRST ONE'S NEEDS

Owners of an over-bonded, screaming cockatoo frequently consider a second bird as a fix. It rarely is. You now have two birds needing 4 to 6 hours each, two cages, two vet bills, and a real possibility that they dislike each other or that one is injured. The interventions on pages 16, 15 and 18 address the actual problem. Get a second cockatoo because you want one and can serve one, not as a treatment.

QUARANTINE EVEN IF IT IS YOUR ONLY BIRD

A 30-day settling period in a quiet room, with a vet exam at the start of it, is good for a single new cockatoo too. It catches problems early, gives the bird the low-pressure start page 18 asks for, and stops the intense first-weeks over-bonding that causes so much trouble later.

Legal status, CITES & state rules

Broadly legal, with real exceptions that depend on which cockatoo you own.

In the great majority of US states a pet cockatoo raises no legal question at all. Idaho and Colorado clear pet birds as a category outright; Oklahoma's noncontrolled exotic-species exemption names cockatoos specifically; New Hampshire and Montana name the parrot order or family as unregulated. Where a state names a parrot, it is almost always the monk parakeet.

CITES DOES NOT MAKE OWNING A COCKATOO ILLEGAL

CITES governs **international trade**, not domestic ownership, so an Appendix I listing does not by itself make a captive-bred bird illegal to keep. It matters for two reasons: a state can key its own rule off the listing, and moving a bird across an international border is a serious permitting exercise.

WHERE	STATUS	WHY
Maine , for the Moluccan, yellow-crested and umbrella	Permit required	Maine clears the parrot order from its permit requirement, then carves out any species on CITES Appendix I or the IUCN's Endangered, Critically Endangered or Extinct in the Wild tiers. The Moluccan and yellow-crested are Appendix I; the umbrella is IUCN Endangered though only Appendix II, the looser list, traded under permit
Maine , for the galah, cockatiel and other smaller species	Legal, no permit	Not on Appendix I or those IUCN tiers
Arkansas	Legal	Five cockatoo species, the Appendix I Moluccan and yellow-crested among them, are named on the unrestricted list with no conservation carve-out
Hawaii	Conditional, an import process	White cockatoos, the galah, gang-gang, black cockatoos and palm cockatoo are conditionally approved. Entry needs an import permit, pre-departure quarantine, health certification and permanent identification. A process, not a ban
California, Virginia	Legal	The only parrot on either state's list is the monk parakeet
New Jersey	Permit	Easy to read backwards. Being off the potentially dangerous table at 4.8(a) only means a bird is not banned. The exempt list at 4.4 decides, and its nine birds include no cockatoo, so 4.5 requires a permit. The Division also treats an IUCN Red List entry as an endangered listing, and the umbrella is Endangered and the Moluccan Vulnerable, so for those two the answer may be harder than a permit
Vermont	Banned	An inverted-list state. The Domestic Species List clears psittacines one binomial at a time, and <i>Cacatua</i> is on none of the three lists, so it is treated as Restricted
Massachusetts	Depends on the species	Parrots are exempt as a family, but 9.01(3)(b) bars exempting any IUCN-listed species. The umbrella, Moluccan and yellow-crested land in a permit tier MassWildlife says it does not issue for pets; least-concern species such as the Major Mitchell's clear it, and near-threatened Goffin's is unclear
Everywhere else	Generally legal	No state-level restriction found

THREE THINGS TO CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY, WHATEVER YOUR STATE SAYS

Your lease or HOA (homeowners association). A noise clause is far more likely to end a cockatoo's stay than a wildlife statute is. Page 19.

Local ordinances on exotic animals and noise sit under state law and on no state list.

Paperwork on the bird. Hatch records, band or microchip details, and CITES documents if it was ever imported. An undocumented bird is hard to move, sell or place later. Page 31.

This page is a summary of publicly available rules as of September 2026 and is not legal advice. State lists are amended, and the definitive answer for your address is your own state wildlife agency.

The sixty-year bird

Succession and rehoming, written down now, while nothing has gone wrong.

A cockatoo typically lives **25 to 45 years**, and the larger species reach 70 to 80 or more. A cockatoo bought by a forty-year-old will very plausibly outlive them, and one bought by a sixty-year-old almost certainly will. That is a planning problem, and it is the most neglected part of owning this species.

THE DEFAULT OUTCOME, IF YOU DO NOTHING

The bird goes to whoever is sorting out your affairs, at the worst possible week, having just lost the only person it was bonded to. Rescues are full, and cockatoos are the bird they take in most. An unplanned cockatoo gets passed through several homes, and each move makes the next one harder.

What a plan actually contains

ELEMENT	DETAIL
A named person, who has agreed	Not "my daughter will probably take it": an actual conversation, an actual yes, ideally someone who has handled the bird. Name a backup, because one name is not a plan across forty years
A named organization as the fallback	A parrot sanctuary or species rescue, contacted in advance and asked whether they run a placement or bequest program. Many do, and their requirements usually include documentation you have to keep from now on
Money attached to the bird	A cockatoo costs \$878 to \$1,995 a year, so inheriting one without funds is inheriting a bill, which is why so many bequeathed parrots end up in rescues. A pet trust, a life-insurance arrangement or a specific bequest all work; a verbal promise does not
It in writing, in the will	Pets are legally property, so an animal cannot inherit money directly: property cannot own property. Name the bird, the person, the fallback, attach the funds. A pet trust is the instrument built for it, and as of 2026 all 50 states and DC (the District of Columbia) have pet trust laws, though each differs, so this is a conversation with an estate attorney in your state
A care file that goes with the bird	This book, pages 40 and 41 filled in, the vet's details, hatch date, band or chip number, any CITES paperwork, and what this bird likes, fears and has been trained to do

If you need to rehome now

Rehoming is not a failure, and doing it well is a real kindness. Doing it badly is how a bird reaches its fifth home by twelve.

- **A reputable rescue or sanctuary first**, never a classified ad. They screen, they know what a cockatoo needs, and they take the bird back if a placement fails
- **Be honest** about screaming, plucking, biting and bonding history. A hidden problem produces another failed placement, and the bird pays for it
- **Send the whole care file**, logs and vet history included
- **Never free to a good home**. A bird advertised free attracts exactly the people who have not costed the next forty years
- **Warn the new home to expect a transition**, and to have the bird seen. A rehomed cockatoo commonly screams, eats less and refuses handling for weeks. Describe what it does rather than what it feels: Merck treats reduced morning vocalizing and reduced interaction as **potential signs of illness**, so the first move is a vet check rather than an assumption about grief. VCA puts the first exam within 1 to 2 weeks of acquiring any bird

FILL THIS IN TODAY

Named guardian _____

Sanctuary fallback _____

Phone, date agreed _____

Funds, and where _____

Backup guardian _____

In the will on _____

Setup checklist & targets

Print this one. Work down it before the bird arrives, or use it to audit a setup you already have.

The cage and the room

- ☐ At least 36×24×48 in (91×61×122 cm); target 48×48×60 in (122×122×152 cm)
- ☐ Bar spacing 3/4 to 1 in (19 to 25 mm), heavy gauge
- ☐ Stainless or heavy powder-coated. Never galvanized
- ☐ Padlocks or clips on every door and feeder hatch
- ☐ Play top or a separate play stand, bought at the same time
- ☐ Perches 3/4 to 2 in (19 to 51 mm), varied material and height
- ☐ A social room the family actually uses
- ☐ Not the kitchen, and not on the same air as it
- ☐ Hard floor or a washable mat under the cage
- ☐ HEPA air purifier fitted and running
- ☐ 10 to 12 hours of real darkness achievable, or a sleep cage
- ☐ Cables covered, blinds cords secured, houseplants checked

Food, kit and paperwork

- ☐ Formulated large-parrot pellets bought
- ☐ A week of dark green and dark orange vegetables
- ☐ Nuts, counted, for training only
- ☐ No grit anywhere in the house
- ☐ Foraging toys, plus a supply of cardboard and paper
- ☐ Untreated softwood and palm, in quantity
- ☐ Digital scale in 1 g steps, with a perch fitted
- ☐ Large travel carrier, assembled and tried
- ☐ First-aid box packed. Page 27
- ☐ Avian vet found, after-hours number written down
- ☐ Well-bird exam and PCR panel booked for week one
- ☐ Succession plan started. Page 31

Nonstick cookware replaced. Not moved, replaced

- ☐ Every nonstick pan gone, or the bird permanently in a separate air space from the kitchen
- ☐ Oven self-clean cycle never to be used
- ☐ Aerosols, air fresheners, plug-ins and scented candles out of the house

The numbers, all in one place

Cage minimum / target	36×24×48 in / 48×48×60 in
Bar spacing	3/4 to 1 in (19 to 25 mm)
Perch diameter	3/4 to 2 in (19 to 51 mm), varied
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Darkness	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted
Diet	75 to 80% pellets, vegetables most of the other 20 to 25%, seed under 10%
Interaction	4 to 6 hours most days, including two training sessions
Quarantine a new bird	30 to 45 days in a separate room, nearer 90 with other birds, plus testing

Emergency & quick targets card

Fill this in today. Cut it out and put it on the fridge, not in a drawer.

AVIAN VET

Name _____

Phone _____

Hours _____

AFTER HOURS / EMERGENCY

Name _____

Phone _____

Drive time _____

THIS BIRD

Name, species _____

Hatch date, band or chip _____

Sex, and how confirmed _____

Baseline weight (g) _____

BEHAVIOR & GUARDIANSHIP

Avian behavior consultant _____

Named guardian _____

Sanctuary fallback _____

GO NOW, DO NOT WAIT UNTIL MORNING

Labored breathing, tail bobbing, open beak, clicking. Bleeding from anywhere, including a broken blood feather. Sitting on the cage floor. A hen straining or with a swollen abdomen. Any cat or dog contact, however small. A fall, a burn, or a suspected PTFE exposure. Seizures, one-sided weakness, or sudden collapse. Discharge from eyes, nose or mouth.

Targets, at a glance

Cage minimum / target	36×24×48 in (91×61×122 cm) / 48×48×60 in (122×122×152 cm)
Bar spacing	3/4 to 1 in (19 to 25 mm)
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Warm carrier, sick bird	75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), upper end. Too hot looks like sleek feathers, wings out, open beak
Darkness, normal	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted
Light, to stop laying	8 hours a day, under vet advice
Diet split	75 to 80% pellets / 20 to 25% fresh, mostly vegetables / seed under 10%
Weight, act on	A fall of about 10% from baseline, or three declining weighings
Breathing at rest	15 to 40 a minute, tail still
Abnormal droppings	Vet if unchanged after about 24 hours
PTFE danger point	About 536°F (280°C). An empty pan reaches it in minutes

Dates to write down

Pellet bag opened _____

Air purifier filter changed _____

Last wellness exam _____

Next exam due _____

Budget & shopping list

Itemized, and the lines add up to the totals. US dollars, 2026.

Getting set up

ITEM	LOW	REALISTIC
Cage: heavy powder-coated at the low end, stainless at the high	\$850	\$2,200
Play stand or a play-top attachment	\$120	\$400
Perches, varied diameter and material	\$40	\$100
Stainless dishes and swing-out feeders	\$30	\$70
Toys, including a large-parrot foraging set	\$80	\$250
Padlocks or spring clips for every hatch	\$15	\$40
HEPA air purifier	\$90	\$250
Digital scale, 1 g steps, with a perch	\$25	\$60
Large travel carrier	\$80	\$200
First bag of pellets	\$25	\$60
Equipment subtotal	\$1,355	\$3,630
The bird: Goffin's or galah at the low end, Moluccan at the high	\$700	\$3,500
Well-bird exam with a PBF test, week one	\$140	\$210
Total to be properly set up	\$2,195	\$7,340
Adoption instead of purchase replaces the bird line with a rescue fee of	\$300	\$800
A psittacosis PCR for the page 29 panel adds, at the lab	\$25	\$25

Every year after that

ITEM	LOW	REALISTIC
Food: pellets, vegetables, fruit and nuts, at \$20 to \$50 a month	\$240	\$600
Toys and destructible material , the biggest line	\$400	\$900
Perch replacement	\$60	\$150
Air purifier filters	\$60	\$140
Paper liner and cleaning supplies	\$40	\$90
Annual avian wellness exam	\$78	\$115
Annual total	\$878	\$1,995
Which is, per month	\$73	\$166
Across a 40-year life, before a single emergency	\$35,120	\$79,800

TOY REPLACEMENT IS NOT OPTIONAL AND NOT A ROUNDING ERROR

Cockatoos destroy wooden toys extremely fast, and constant destructible enrichment is a welfare need rather than a luxury. Skipping it is not a saving, it is the direct cause of the plucking on page 24. Half that line can cost nothing if you use cardboard, paper and untreated offcuts. Some owners also budget **\$300 to \$500 a year for insurance**.

WHERE TO SAVE, AND WHERE NOT TO

Not the cage, because a cheap one gets bent, opened or replaced. Not the locks, the purifier or the pellets. **Do** save on destructibles, which are cardboard, paper, palm and untreated offcuts, and on perches, which grow on unsprayed apple and willow for free.

First 30 days checklist

In order. The hardest instruction in this book is on days 1 to 14: do less than you want to.

READ THIS BEFORE DAY ONE

Everything in you will want to spend the first two weeks holding this bird. **Do not.** Intense one-on-one time in the first weeks cements the anxious dependency that produces screaming and plucking later. Be present, be predictable, share the bird around the household. Page 18.

Days 1 to 3: settle, do not handle

- ☐ Cage set up and standing *before* the bird came home, in its permanent spot
- ☐ Whatever food the bird was already on, in the dish. Change the diet later
- ☐ Sleep routine fixed from night one: same lights-out time, 10 to 12 hours
- ☐ Sit in the room and talk or read aloud. Minimal handling
- ☐ Weigh daily and start the log on page 40

Week 1

- ☐ Well-bird exam and PCR panel booked and attended
- ☐ Quarantine room running if you have other birds. Page 29
- ☐ Baseline weight established across seven days
- ☐ Every adult in the house doing part of the daily routine
- ☐ Foraging started at stage one, food visible on top of a toy. Page 15
- ☐ Destructible material supply established and being used

Week 2

- ☐ First training sessions, five to ten minutes, once or twice a day. Page 16
- ☐ Sessions rotated between people in the household
- ☐ Pellet conversion started, one method chosen. Page 12
- ☐ Weight watched daily through the conversion
- ☐ Bath offered daily: a shower perch or a misting
- ☐ Leaving and returning to the room casually, many times a day

Week 3

- ☐ Room bird-proofed and the pre-flight check practiced. Page 11
- ☐ First supervised out-of-cage sessions on the stand
- ☐ Station cue introduced, so the bird has somewhere to go that is not you
- ☐ Calm, self-directed behavior being rewarded deliberately
- ☐ Foraging moved to stage two, food wrapped in paper

Week 4

- ☐ Sex confirmed by DNA test if it is not already known. Page 21
- ☐ Voluntary carrier entry started with a nut reward
- ☐ Toys rotated for the first time, not added to
- ☐ Emergency card on page 33 filled in and on the fridge
- ☐ Succession conversation started with a named person. Page 31
- ☐ Next wellness exam penciled into the planner on page 41

WHAT NORMAL SETTLING LOOKS LIKE

A new cockatoo may be quiet and watchful for days, eat less, refuse to step up, or be immediately and overwhelmingly affectionate. All are normal. A quiet bird holding its weight is settling; a quiet bird losing weight is ill, and the scale is the only way to tell. Page 23.

Symptom quick reference

What you see, what it usually means, and how fast to move.

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSES	ACT
Tail bobbing, open beak, clicking	Respiratory disease, chlamydiosis, aspergillosis, vitamin A deficiency, abdominal fat, PTFE exposure	Today. Page 27
Sitting on the cage floor	Advanced illness of almost any kind, egg binding, injury, poisoning	Today. Page 23
Straining, swollen abdomen, wide stance, leg weakness	Egg binding	Today. Page 22
Bleeding	Broken blood feather, self-mutilation, cat or dog contact, cage injury	Today. Page 27
Weight down about 10% from baseline	Failing pellet conversion, illness, parasites, tumor	Today. Page 21
Breathless after mild exertion, or lame	Obesity and abdominal fat, a lipoma interfering with movement, heavy metal	48 hours. Page 26
Beak or nails overgrown, soft, flaking or oddly colored	Liver disease. A visible early sign, worth checking weekly	48 hours. Page 26
Beak unusually glossy or shiny, feathers clubbed or pinched	PBFD, through loss of the powder down	PCR test. Page 25
Lime-green droppings	Liver disease, chlamydiosis	48 hours. Page 28
Watery droppings, feces still formed	Polyuria: watery food, stress, or kidney disease	Vet if it persists past 24 hours
Unformed droppings, no solid part	True diarrhea. <i>Giardia</i> , bacterial infection, chlamydiosis	48 hours. Page 28
Feathers chewed or missing, head untouched	Feather-destructive behavior. Medical first, then boredom, isolation, sleep debt, hormones	Vet, then page 24
Symmetrical feather loss, pin feathers, head included, bird well	A normal molt	Support it. Page 24
Broken skin, open wound the bird is working at	Self-mutilation, which is the serious end of plucking	Today , and a behaviorist after. Page 24
A sudden change in vocal or behavioral pattern	Can signal pain or illness, not just an emotional cause	Vet visit to rule out. Page 19
Screaming that escalates through the day	An unmet contact call: company, occupation, sleep, an unpredictable routine	Page 19
Screaming that starts when one person leaves the room	Separation-related behavior from over-bonding	Page 18
Sudden aggression in a previously sweet bird aged 3 to 7	Sexual maturity, plus hormonal triggers you can control	Page 17
Excessive drinking and urination	Vitamin A deficiency, kidney disease, lead or zinc	48 hours. Page 27
Regurgitating onto a toy, a person or a mirror	Courtship behavior, not illness. Vomiting sticks to the face and chest instead	Page 22

A RULE FOR THE AMBIGUOUS CASES

"Wait and see" costs more than a consultation does. If two things here are true at once, or anything is true alongside a falling weight, treat it as the urgent version. And for anything behavioral: rule out medical first, then work the behavior.

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

What good care actually looks like as a set of habits, and a predictable day is itself a treatment.

Every day

- ☐ Uncover, greet and offer a bath at the same time. Page 10
- ☐ Fresh water in washed dishes, at least once, usually twice
- ☐ The day's ration into foraging, across several sites. Page 15
- ☐ Fresh vegetables in, and out again after two hours
- ☐ Fresh destructible material: cardboard, paper, softwood
- ☐ Paper liner changed, droppings read as you do it
- ☐ **One or two training sessions, five to ten minutes**
- ☐ Hours out of the cage, in a proofed room or on the stand
- ☐ Calm, self-directed behavior rewarded at least a few times
- ☐ Weigh before the first feed, then look the bird over
- ☐ Lights out at the same time, 10 to 12 hours of dark
- ☐ Pre-flight check before any free flight. Page 11

Every week

- ☐ Review the week of weights on page 40
- ☐ Feel the keel during a head scratch
- ☐ Rotate toys and change the foraging presentation
- ☐ Damp-wipe the room, never dry dusting
- ☐ Inspect cage hardware, clips and locks for chew damage

Every month

- ☐ Cage deep clean, tray and grate included
- ☐ Perches replaced or re-cut as they are destroyed
- ☐ Air purifier filter checked, replaced on schedule
- ☐ Weight trend reviewed across the month, not just today

Seasonally, and once a year

WHEN	WHAT
Lengthening days	Hormonal season. Expect regurgitating, cavity hunting, territorial biting and more noise. Tighten the photoperiod, remove every cavity, stop all body petting, keep the training running. Pages 9 and 22
After the breeding season	Molt. A quieter, hungrier, touchier bird for several weeks, covered in sore pin feathers. More bathing, more protein, less handling. Page 24
Winter	Drier air, more heating, more dust in a closed house. Bathe more often, run the purifier harder, and remember an oven's self-clean cycle is a PTFE source
Once a year	Wellness exam, even when nothing is wrong. In a bird that hides illness this well, the annual exam is where problems are actually found
Every few years	Review the succession plan on page 31. People move and change their minds across four decades

Enrichment & training log

DATE	SESSION OR ENRICHMENT	WHO	NOTES

Power outages, travel & transport

For a bird, the danger in an outage is not the cold. It is what people light to fix the cold.

THE RULE THAT INVERTS FROM EVERY OTHER PET

A reptile in a power cut is a temperature problem. **A cockatoo in a power cut is a fumes problem.** Candles, kerosene and propane heaters, a gas stove left on for warmth, and a wood stove that smokes are all far more dangerous to a bird than a cold night is. A generator runs outside and **at least 20 feet from any door, window or vent**, the figure from the CDC (US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention), and the CPSC (US Consumer Product Safety Commission) rules out running one in or *near* an enclosed space, so an open garage door does not qualify. Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in the house. If the power goes out, the first thing you decide is what you are *not* going to light in the bird's air.

If the power goes out

- **Keep feeding.** Food and water stay available whatever else is happening
- **Move the cage to the warmest interior room**, away from windows and exterior doors, and cover three sides with blankets to hold warmth while leaving airflow at the front
- **Body heat beats fire.** A carrier under a blanket in an occupied room is safer than any flame
- **Ventilate anything you do burn.** If a heater has to run, it runs in a different room with the door closed and a window cracked, and the bird is not in that room
- **The purifier being off is not an emergency**, but the dust builds fast. Open a window in another room and damp-wipe more often until the power is back. Page 10

The go bag

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Large travel carrier with a low fixed perch | ☐ Flashlight, towel, paper liner, first-aid box |
| ☐ Three days of pellets in a sealed bag | ☐ A copy of pages 33 and 39 |
| ☐ Bottled water and a clip-on dish | ☐ Band or microchip number, and any CITES paperwork |
| ☐ Nuts, for a bird refusing to eat | ☐ Photo of the bird, on your phone and printed |

In the car

RULE	WHY
A carrier, not the cage	A cage is a box of perches and toys to be thrown around in. A carrier with one low perch is safer, and for most birds the smaller space is calming rather than distressing
A carrier this beak cannot open	Check the door latch specifically, and add a clip. A cockatoo loose in a moving car is a genuinely dangerous situation for everyone in it
Cover it	Less visual input, much less stress. Leave one side open for airflow
Belt it in, on the back seat	Never the trunk, never a lap, never the front seat with an airbag
Water at stops, not in the carrier	A full dish soaks the bird, and a soaked bird chills
Never leave the bird in a parked car	Not for five minutes. A closed car in the sun kills a bird faster than it kills a dog
No air freshener, no smoking, no vaping	A car is a very small volume of air. Page 11

TRAIN VOLUNTARY CARRIER ENTRY, NOW

Leave the carrier open in the room, put nuts in it, and reward the bird for walking in. Page 16. A cockatoo that enters its carrier for a reward can be moved in ninety seconds during an evacuation or a 10pm emergency. One that has never seen it is a fight in a stressful moment, with a beak that can take a finger.

Pet-sitter sheet

Fill it in, print it, and leave it taped near the cage. Assume the sitter has never kept a large parrot.

THE BIRD

Name, species _____

Sex _____

Normal weight (g) _____

REACH ME

Phone _____

Backup contact _____

Vet + after hours _____

Every day, please

- ☐ Fresh water in washed dishes. The bird dunks food in it, so it will need doing twice
- ☐ Pellets are the main food, not a supplement. Refill in the morning
- ☐ Fresh vegetables in the morning, and out again after about two hours
- ☐ Put fresh cardboard, paper or wood in every day. Destroying it is the point
- ☐ Change the paper in the tray, and glance at the droppings while you do it
- ☐ Spend real time near the cage and talk to the bird. This matters more than you think
- ☐ Lights out at the usual time. This bird needs 10 to 12 hours of dark and quiet

PLEASE NEVER, IN THIS HOUSE

Do not use nonstick cookware. An overheated nonstick pan releases a gas that kills birds, often with no other sign. Use the stainless or cast iron pans.

No aerosols, air fresheners, scented candles or plug-ins anywhere in the house while the bird is here.

Do not open the cage or let the bird out unless we have specifically arranged it and shown you how. This beak can take stitches, and a loose cockatoo is hard to get back.

Do not put your fingers through the bars. Use the perch or the target stick we have left out.

No avocado, chocolate, caffeine, alcohol, onion or garlic, ever, in any amount.

Do not shout at the bird if it screams. It gets louder. Answer it quietly or leave the room.

Call me if you see

- ☐ The bird sitting on the floor of the cage
- ☐ Breathing with an open beak, or the tail pumping
- ☐ Blood anywhere, or a wound it keeps picking at
- ☐ Fluffed up and not moving much, for hours
- ☐ No droppings on the paper since yesterday
- ☐ An egg. Please leave it exactly where it is and call

Where things are

Pellets _____

Vegetables, nuts and treats _____

Cardboard, paper and wood _____

Paper liner and cleaning kit _____

Carrier, target stick and first-aid box _____

Lights out at _____

[illegible]

Weigh daily, at the same time of day, before the first feed, and never skip it through a diet conversion, a molt, or a change in how food is delivered. Write the number even when it is boring, because the boring numbers are what make one interesting number readable. Act on a drop of more than about 10% from the bird's own baseline, or any steady decline across three weighings. Take this page to the vet, and keep it with the care file on page 31.

Equipment & vet log

What was replaced, what was treated, and what is due next.

Equipment & consumables

ITEM	REPLACED	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Perches			
Air purifier filter			
Pellet bag opened			
Cage hardware, locks and clips checked			

Veterinary

DATE	REASON	WEIGHT (G)	FINDINGS, TREATMENT, FOLLOW-UP

Twelve-month planner

MONTH	WEIGHED	WELLNESS EXAM	FILTER CHANGED	NOTES
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	

REFERENCE

Glossary

Terms used in this book, in the sense they are used here.

Bird fancier's lung	Hypersensitivity pneumonitis in people, caused by prolonged exposure to avian proteins in feather dust and dried droppings. Page 10
Blood feather	A growing feather with a live blood supply in the shaft. Dark and full at the base, and it bleeds freely if broken or cut. Pages 20 and 27
bpm	Beats per minute, the unit a heart rate is counted in. A resting cockatoo's heart rate scales with its size: about 147 bpm in a 500 g bird and about 127 in a 1,000 g bird, far faster than a person's. Pages 4 and 23
CDC	Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the US federal public health agency. It wrote the psittacosis compendium behind the 30-day quarantine with the NASPHV, and it is the source of the rule that a generator runs at least 20 feet from any door, window or vent. Pages 38 and 44
Chlamydiosis	Infection with <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> . Called psittacosis in people. Page 27
Chronic egg laying	Repeated clutches out of season, driven by the environment rather than by a mate. Page 22
CITES	The Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora, the international convention governing trade in endangered species. It regulates trade, not domestic ownership. Page 30
Contact call	A loud call used to locate flock members out of sight. Most cockatoo screaming is this. Page 19
Corticosterone	The main avian stress hormone, used in the plucking study as an objective measure of whether a treatment worked. Page 16
CPBC	Certified Parrot Behavior Consultant, a professional credential in parrot behavior. This is the specialist to call when screaming, biting or plucking has become entrenched, and the number to add to the emergency card in week one. Page 45
CPSC	Consumer Product Safety Commission, the US federal agency that oversees the safety of household products. Its rule is that a generator never runs in or near an enclosed space, so an open garage door does not make a garage safe for one. Page 38
DC	The District of Columbia, the US capital. It is not a state, but like all 50 states it has a pet trust law, the legal instrument for leaving a bird, a named caregiver and the money for its care in your will. Page 31
et al.	Et alii, Latin for "and others". Used in a citation when a study has more authors than are worth listing, so van Zeeland et al. means van Zeeland and colleagues. Page 44
Eye pinning	Rapid dilation and contraction of the pupil, signaling high arousal. Excitement or aggression depending on what else the bird is doing. Page 17
Foraging	Working for food rather than eating it from a bowl. A wild parrot spends much of its day doing it. Page 15
HEPA	High-efficiency particulate air, a filter grade that traps very fine particles. A HEPA purifier running in the bird's room is the single most effective step against cockatoo feather dust, and its filters are a running cost in the budget. Pages 10 and 34
Hepatic lipodosis	Fatty liver disease, usually from a seed-heavy diet. Page 26
HOA	Homeowners association, the body that sets and enforces the rules of a housing development or condominium building. A noise clause in its rules, or in a lease, is far more likely to end a cockatoo's stay than any wildlife law. Page 30
Hypovitaminosis A	Vitamin A deficiency. The commonest nutritional disease in pet birds. Page 26
IUCN	International Union for Conservation of Nature, which keeps the Red List, the global list of threatened species. Some states key their permit rules to it, which is why the Endangered umbrella needs a permit in Maine although it is not on CITES Appendix I. Page 30

REFERENCE

Glossary, continued

Terms K to Z.

Keel	The ridge of breastbone down the front of the bird, used to judge body condition by feel. Page 21
Lipoma	A benign fatty tumor, common in overweight cockatoos. Page 26
Molt	Orderly, symmetrical replacement of the plumage. Page 24
MSD	Merck Sharp & Dohme, Merck's name outside the US and Canada. The MSD and Merck Veterinary Manuals are one reference under two names, and the source of this book's toxin, nutrition and multi-bird quarantine figures. Page 44
NASPHV	National Association of State Public Health Veterinarians, which writes US guidance on animal diseases that spread to people. With the CDC it publishes the <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> compendium, the source of the 30-day quarantine with testing for a new bird. Page 44
NHLBI	National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute, the US government's heart and lung research institute. It lists pet birds in the home as a risk factor for bird fancier's lung in their own right, which is why the air purifier is part of the setup. Page 10
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease. An incurable circovirus first described in Australian cockatoos. Page 25
PCR	Polymerase chain reaction, a lab test that detects a disease's DNA. A PCR panel in week one screens a new bird for PBFD, polyomavirus and chlamydia, and it is what makes a quarantine more than waiting. Page 29
Photoperiod	The length of the light part of the day. The main lever on hormonal behavior. Page 9
Pin feather	A new feather still in its waxy keratin sheath. Normal during a molt, and sore to touch. Page 24
Polyuria	Excess urine, with the fecal part still formed. Not the same as diarrhea. Page 28
Powder down	Specialized feathers that break down into a fine dust used in grooming. Cockatoos produce a great deal of it. Page 10
PTFE	Polytetrafluoroethylene, the nonstick coating whose fumes kill birds when overheated. Page 11
Regurgitation	Deliberate bringing up of food as courtship, aimed at a mate, a toy or a person. Not vomiting. Page 22
Station	A trained cue to go to a named perch and stay. The behavior that gets a bird off your shoulder politely. Page 16
Target training	Teaching the bird to touch its beak to a stick. The foundation for everything else, and it keeps hands away from the beak. Page 16
UC Davis	University of California, Davis, a leading US veterinary school. Its Clinical Animal Behavior Service is a source for the 10 to 12 hours of darkness and quiet this species needs every night. Page 45
Urates	The chalky white part of a dropping, uric acid rather than urine. Page 28
UV, UVB	Ultraviolet, the invisible part of sunlight beyond violet. UVB (ultraviolet B) is the part birds use to make vitamin D3, and window glass filters most of it, so a sunny window is a heat trap rather than a light source. Page 9
VCA	Veterinary Centers of America, a large US chain of veterinary hospitals. Its client pages are one of this book's main sources, including the 75 to 80% pellet diet and the 25 to 45 year life span. Page 12
Vitamin D3	Cholecalciferol, the form of vitamin D that lets a bird absorb calcium. A bird makes it from UVB light or gets it from a pellet diet, and without it the calcium in the diet cannot be used, which matters most in a laying hen. Page 22
Zoonotic	Passing from animals to people. Psittacosis is. Page 27

REFERENCE

Sources & further reading

Where the numbers in this book came from.

SOURCE	WHAT IT SUPPLIED
LafeberVet, <i>Basic Information Sheet: Cockatoo</i>	Body weights by species, adult length, the narrower 30 to 45 year life span on page 46, sexual maturity at 3 to 4 and 5 to 6 years, incubation and clutch size, weaning ages, body temperature, heart rate by body weight, respiratory rate, bar spacing, perch diameter and the household temperature range
Lafeber, <i>Umbrella Cockatoo</i> species profile	The up-to-70-year life span, the extremely high noise level, and that this is not a good first bird or a child's pet
VCA Animal Hospitals, <i>Cockatoos: Feeding</i>	The 75 to 80% pellet share, the conversion methods, the grit warning, the supplement guidance, the small-handful portion rule, and the toxic food list
VCA, <i>Psittacine Beak and Feather Disease in Pet Birds</i>	The circovirus, over 50 affected species, the peracute, acute and chronic forms, the beak and powder-down signs in cockatoos, transmission through feather dust, the weeks-to-years incubation, PCR diagnosis and prognosis
VCA, <i>Egg Binding in Birds</i>	The clinical signs, the calcium and obesity risk factors, the treatment sequence, and the 8-hour photoperiod intervention
VCA, <i>Birds: Abnormal Droppings</i>	The three components, diet-related fecal color, polyuria against true diarrhea, lime-green droppings and liver disease, and the 24-hour rule
MSD / Merck Veterinary Manual (one manual: MSD, short for Merck Sharp & Dohme, is Merck's name outside the US and Canada), <i>Toxicoses of Pet Birds</i>	PTFE at 280°C (536°F) with acute death as the usual sign and the full source list, lead and zinc household sources and signs, aerosols and tobacco
MSD / Merck, <i>Nutritional Diseases of Pet Birds</i>	Hypovitaminosis A on seed and half-seed diets, obesity at roughly 20% over ideal weight, galahs named among species prone to obesity, and calcium deficiency signs
NASPHV (National Association of State Public Health Veterinarians, which writes US guidance on animal diseases that spread to people) and CDC, <i>Compendium of Measures to Control Chlamydia psittaci Infection Among Humans and Pet Birds</i>	The 30-day quarantine with testing, the 45-day doxycycline course and the shorter 21 to 30 day option, and the human incubation period and illness picture
<i>Assessment and treatment of feather plucking in sulphur-crested cockatoos (Cacatua galerita)</i> , <i>Journal of Animal and Veterinary Advances</i> (2014); van Zeeland et al. (et alii, Latin for "and others", 2009), <i>Applied Animal Behaviour Science</i> 121:75-95	The study design on page 16: haloperidol, socialization, training and feeding enrichment, measured by behavioral observation, feather condition scoring and corticosterone. Its full text is not openly available, so its reported ranking is not repeated. The review lists reinforcement training, environmental enrichment and foraging enrichment together as interventions, without ranking them
Meehan, Millam and Mench (2003), <i>Applied Animal Behaviour Science</i>	That foraging opportunity and increased physical complexity both prevented and reduced psychogenic feather picking in young Amazon parrots
LafeberVet, <i>Basic Information Sheet for the Cockatoo</i>	Iris color as a partial sexing feature in mature white cockatoos, "the male iris is black or dark brown, while females have a light brown or red-brown iris," with immature birds showing a pale gray iris; DNA testing as the reliable method; and the body weights and life span band
NHLBI (National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute), <i>Hypersensitivity Pneumonitis</i> ; Kila et al., <i>Cureus</i> (2025), a case report in a pigeon keeper rather than a psittacine one	Bird fancier's lung on page 10: avian proteins in feather dust and dried droppings, pet birds in the home as a risk factor in their own right, most diagnoses between 50 and 70, irreversible pulmonary fibrosis as the serious complication, and reduction of exposure as part of treatment. The NHLBI is what generalizes the risk to pet birds; the case report documents the mechanism in a pigeon keeper and is cited as that, not as psittacine evidence
Maine Department of Inland Fisheries and Wildlife; Arkansas Game and Fish Commission; Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6.5	Maine's parrot exemption and its CITES and IUCN carve-out, Arkansas's unrestricted list naming five cockatoo species, and Hawaii's conditionally approved animal list and import process

REFERENCE

Sources, continued

The site's own guides behind this package.

SOURCE	WHAT IT SUPPLIED
VCA, <i>Wing Clipping, Blood or Pin Feathers, Taming, Training, Talking to Birds, Clicker and Target Training, New Bird Visit</i> ; Merck, <i>Management, Viral and Skin and Feather Disorders</i>	Blood-feather first aid and why a feather is not pulled at home; the session ramp and the behavior ladder on page 16; the first exam within 1 to 2 weeks; four to seven outermost primaries with secondaries left alone; the 90-day aviary quarantine; the partial second molt; and that reduced vocalizing and interaction are potential signs of illness, which is why page 31 routes a rehomed bird to a vet check
Michigan State University College of Law, Animal Legal & Historical Center; Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006); UC Davis (University of California, Davis, a leading US veterinary school) Clinical Animal Behavior Service; US CDC and CPSC	Companion animals as legal property, so they cannot inherit directly, and pet trust laws in all 50 states and DC as of 2026, page 31; hand-reared against parent-reared behavior, page 6; the 10 to 12 hour sleep figure; the 20-foot generator distance and carbon monoxide guidance, page 38
Pamela Clark, CPBC (Certified Parrot Behavior Consultant, a professional credential), parrot behavior consulting	That cockatoos are among the most consistently relinquished parrots and make up more than half of one specialist consulting practice
VCA, <i>Cockatoos: General Information</i>	The 25 to 45 year typical life span with the larger species at 70 to 80 or more, pages 4, 6 and 31
VCA, <i>Bathing Birds</i>	A bath offered daily, in the morning so the bird is dry by night, pages 10 and 37
Vety, <i>Cockatoo Cost</i> ; Animal Genetics, <i>Avian Fee Schedule</i> ; Colorado Exotic Animal Hospital and Birdhouse Mobile Exotic Veterinary Service price lists; US pet retailer cage prices checked October 2026	Page 34: food at \$20 to \$50 a month, cage ranges by material, a PBFD PCR at \$24.50 at the lab, a pre-purchase exam with PBFD test at about \$140 to \$210, and a wellness exam at \$78 to \$115

Beastly Facts guides drawn on: cockatoo cage setup, feeding, health issues, handling, enrichment, cost and legal status, the screaming and feather plucking deep dive, and the cockatiel and cockatoo comparison, plus the cross-species bird guides written since this edition, which now carry pages this package used to source externally: feather dust and air quality, succession planning for a long-lived pet, parrot training, sexing and body condition, the rehomed parrot, household hazards, photoperiod and sleep, pellet conversion, quarantine, droppings, wing clipping, feather loss and molt, chronic egg laying, emergency and travel, and choosing a pet bird. Every figure was checked against them again for 1.2, and where the package and a site guide differed, the guide's figure is what is printed here.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Five figures where credible references do not match, and what this book prints instead.

FIGURE	THE DISAGREEMENT, AND THE CHOICE
Life span	VCA gives 25 to 45 years, with the larger species at 70 to 80 or more , and that is what is printed here. LafeberVet's information sheet gives a narrower 30 to 45, with Moluccans up to 70, and consumer sources commonly give 40 to 70-plus. The planning consequence on page 31 is the same either way: assume the bird outlives you
Umbrella weight	LafeberVet gives 400 to 700 g for an umbrella. Other references give 1.1 to 1.7 lb, which is roughly 500 to 770 g. The ranges overlap and neither is wrong; the practical answer on page 21 is that your own bird's stable baseline matters far more than the published range
Diet split	Some care references give 60 to 70% pellets for large parrots, and fresh food is sometimes allowed up to 40%. This book prints 75 to 80% pellets , vegetables most of the remaining 20 to 25%, and seed under about 10%
Cage size	36×24×48 in is the commonly cited minimum and 48×48×60 in the frequently recommended target. Neither was picked: page 7 prints the first as a floor and the second as what to buy, and says plainly that no cage that fits in a house is large enough on its own
Cost	The common setup figure of \$900 to \$2,500 covers the cage, perches, bowls and toys, and leaves out the play stand, air purifier, gram scale, carrier and first vet visit. Page 34 itemizes all of them and lands at \$2,195 to \$7,340, the lines summing to the totals

WHAT THIS BOOK PRINTS WITH NO SITE SOURCE AT ALL

At 1.0 this list ran to seven items. All but one now have a companion guide on the site, cross-checked at 1.1 and again at 1.2: the bird fancier's lung, sexing and keel, quarantine, droppings, wing clipping and succession material. What is still carried by this book alone: the **itemized budget on page 34**, the weights and weaning ages by species on pages 4 and 6, and the measured noise figure this book deliberately does **not** print, because no acoustic or veterinary source worth citing gives one. Everything else is sourced on pages 44 and 45.

Version history

VERSION	DATE	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
1.2	Oct 2026	t3	Cross-checked against the site again: life span is now 25 to 45 years with larger species at 70 to 80-plus, the fresh share 20 to 25% with seed under 10%, bathing and weighing daily, quarantine 30 to 45 days, the sick-bird carrier 75 to 80°F, and the budget rebuilt on the site's cage, food and vet prices, while the six-hour foraging figure and the claim that training beat every other treatment are gone. On page 30, New Jersey became a permit state, Vermont a ban, and Massachusetts depends on the species.
1.1	Sep 2026	t3	Corrections pass, cross-checked page by page against the site's cross-species bird articles. Page 31 stopped calling a rehomed bird's withdrawal grief, which Merck lists as a potential sign of illness, and routes it to a vet check; blood-feather first aid was corrected to firm pressure with no pulling at home; weighing moved from weekly to daily; the 45 to 60 day multi-bird quarantine became Merck's 90 days; the training session length became VCA's ramp; and the bird fancier's lung source line was corrected, since the case report behind it documents a pigeon keeper rather than a psittacine one. Added: the hand-raised tradeoff, the juvenile iris, pet trust law, the 48-hour egg marker, and the clipping, molt, generator, metal and droppings figures.
1.0	Sep 2026	t3	First edition

Beastly Facts publishes fact-checked care references for keepers who would rather read one accurate thing than ten contradictory ones. This is a husbandry reference, not veterinary advice, and page 30 is not legal advice.

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